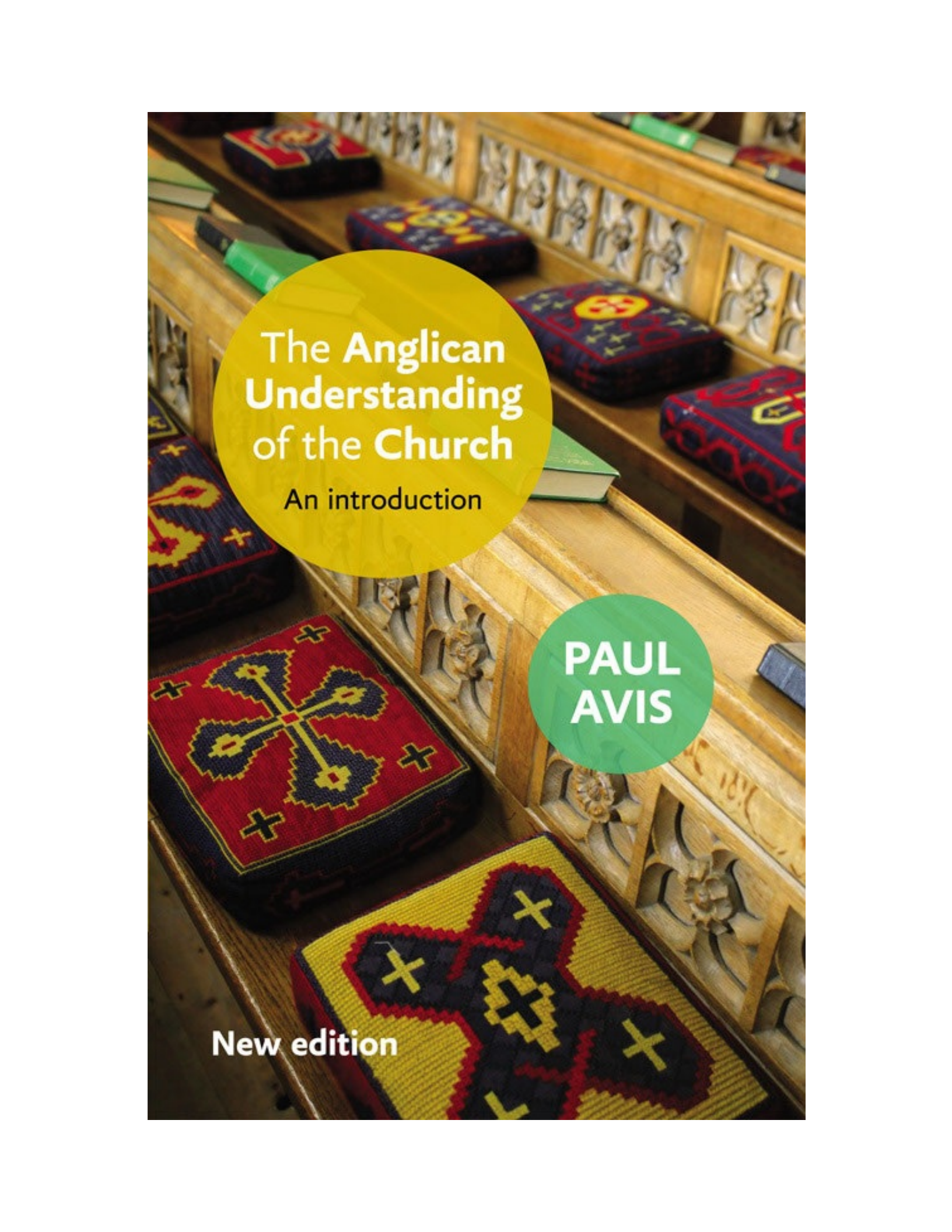


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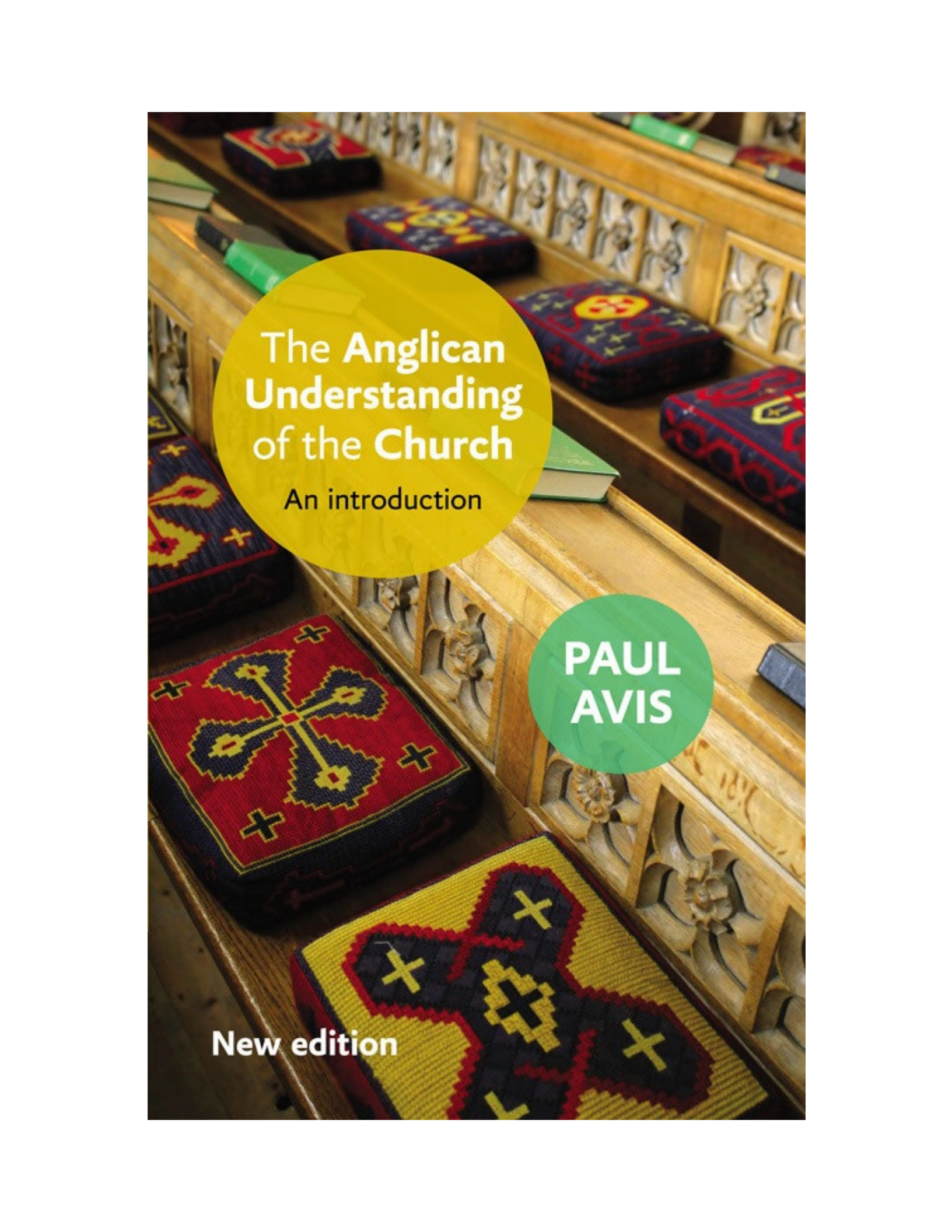
# The Anglican Understanding of the Church

An introduction

PAUL  
AVIS

New edition



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Paul Avis is Canon Theologian of Exeter, honorary Visiting Professor in the Department of Theology of the University of Exeter and Chaplain to the Queen. Formerly the General Secretary of the Council for Christian Unity of the Church of England, he is currently the editor-in-chief of *Ecclesiology*. His recent books include *Anglicanism and the Christian Church: Theological Resources in Historical Perspective* (2002), *A Church Drawing Near: Spirituality and Mission in a Post-Christian Culture* (2003), *A Ministry Shaped by Mission* (2005), *Beyond the Reformation? Authority, Primacy and Unity in the Conciliar Tradition* (2006), *The Identity of Anglicanism: Essentials of Anglican Ecclesiology* (2008) and *Reshaping Ecumenical Theology: The Church Made Whole?* (2010).



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An introduction

Second edition

PAUL AVIS



First published in Great Britain in 2000

Society for Promoting Christian Knowledge

36 Causton Street

London SW1P 4ST

[www.spckpublishing.co.uk](http://www.spckpublishing.co.uk)

Reprinted three times

Second edition published 2013

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*British Library Cataloguing-in-Publication Data*

A catalogue record for this book is available from the British Library

ISBN 978-0-281-06814-2

eBook ISBN 978-0-281-06815-9

Typeset and eBook by Graphicraft Limited, Hong Kong

# Contents

[\*Preface to the revised and expanded edition\*](#)

[1 The spirit of Anglican ecclesiology](#)

[2 Why do Christians need to understand the Church?](#)

[3 The quest for Anglican ecclesiology](#)

[4 Three models of Anglican self-understanding](#)

[5 The threefold appeal of Anglican ecclesiology](#)

[6 The sources of Anglican ecclesiology](#)

[7 The shape of Anglican ecclesiology](#)

[Notes](#)

[Search items for names](#)

## Preface to the revised and expanded edition

This brief introduction to the Anglican understanding of the Church seems to have met a need since it was first published in 2000. My hope then was that it would be useful throughout the Anglican Communion to candidates being considered for ordination, to the increasing numbers preparing for various forms of lay ministry, as well as to clergy who may have had a nagging sense that their ordination training somehow forgot to tell them much about the Church itself and particularly about the Anglican expression of the Church. I stated the hope that many lay synod members, churchwardens and Parochial Church Council or Vestry members would read it. I wanted it to be useful to enquirers, whether they were wondering what the Anglican tradition has to offer them in the marketplace of faiths or whether they were preparing for a process of selection that may lead to training for a recognized form of ministry. I also hoped that this book would assist the understanding of Anglicanism in situations of local ecumenism, such as Local Ecumenical Partnerships, and in the informal discussions and study groups that bring Christians of different church traditions together, especially during Lent. The fact that this little book has remained in print for a dozen years suggests that at least some of these aspirations may have been met.

For this new edition I have revised and expanded the text, updating it to take account of Anglican and ecumenical developments that have brought us to where we are in the second decade of the twenty-first century, enriching the reading lists, as well as giving more endnote references for those who may wish to follow them up. I have also added some questions for reflection and discussion at the end of each chapter. Since writing the original text in the late 1990s, my own Anglican and ecumenical study and experience have been hugely enriched by deeper research, much writing and opportunities to serve the Church of England and the Anglican Communion in ecumenical and ecclesiological work. I have had the privilege of lecturing in many member Churches of the Communion. But this revision has also given me the opportunity to have some second thoughts about some of the ways that I put things in the first edition. I have also tried to make the argument less focused on the Church of England, in the hope that the book will also be serviceable in many other member Churches of the Anglican Communion.

Several introductions to the Anglican tradition generally or to the history and nature of the Anglican Communion are available, and several of them will be recommended as we go along. But I am not aware of anything similar on the Anglican understanding of the Church at this level and length. I have tried not to make too many assumptions about the reader's previous knowledge. Those who want to go into greater depth will find some pointers to further reading at the end of each chapter, including more advanced studies by the present author. There is also the journal *Ecclesiology*, of which I have the honour to be editor-in-chief ([www.brill.nl/ecso](http://www.brill.nl/ecso)). So I hope that this modest book will prove to be the start of a journey of discovery for many in the Anglican Communion and in other Christian traditions who may be drawn to it by curiosity about this attractive and infuriating thing called Anglicanism!

*Paul Avis*

### The spirit of Anglican ecclesiology

For all its imperfections, Anglican theology has often been marked by a spirit of openness towards other Christian traditions. Christian Churches have sometimes spoken of themselves as though they were the only true Church of Jesus Christ. They have tended to articulate their Church's standpoint as though it were the only true ecclesiology – that is, without creating the necessary space in our minds between what can be said of any particular tradition and what may be said of the Church of Christ as such. This was inevitable where a church's ecclesiology included the claim that it was to be identified without remainder with the Church of Christ and that other ecclesial bodies were somehow outside the catholic Church. That claim has been modified as far as the Roman Catholic Church is concerned as a result of the Second Vatican Council (1962–5), though much ambiguity remains; and now questions are even being raised by some in the Orthodox Churches, though they certainly have not abandoned their claim to be the one true Church. When such absolute and exclusive claims are made for any Church, a truly ecumenical approach to ecclesiology is ruled out. Obviously, the true Church cannot allow the views that 'heretics and schismatics' may have of the Church to influence how it understands itself!

A distinctive feature of Anglican ecclesiology, I suggest, is that it has not been carried on in the insularity that sometimes accompanies absolute and exclusive claims for one's own Church. I do not think that Anglicans have ever made those claims. The Church of England, even at its most robust (say at the Restoration of the monarchy and episcopate in 1660–62) has never regarded itself as the only true Church; it has always recognized the existence of other Churches – Protestant, Roman Catholic or Orthodox. As a result, Anglican ecclesiology has openly drawn on the theological resources of other traditions; it has been practised in an ecumenical spirit and by a synthetic method. The early English Reformers, however harshly they may have spoken of the Church of Rome, recognized their affinity with the Reformation churches on the Continent, regarding them as sister churches. The Thirty-Nine Articles borrow unashamedly

from the Lutheran Augsburg Confession (1530), especially in what they say about the Church. Richard Hooker (d. 1600) holds in his theological armoury not only the thought of St Thomas Aquinas, but the learning of the more recent and contemporary Roman Catholic divines, as well as the Reformers, and deploys them with a good conscience at will.

Hooker spoke of the various particular or national Churches as being like the oceans of the world, separate but contiguous. Later writers employed the ‘branch theory’ of the Church to account for the existence of the Roman Catholic and Orthodox Churches alongside the Anglican. Anglican ecclesiology has never assumed that it is the only one there is and, therefore, has never made the mistake of exclusively identifying what may be said of Anglicanism with what may be said of the one, holy, catholic and apostolic Church of Jesus Christ. That seems to be an important clue to the distinctive spirit of Anglican ecclesiology. It is captured superbly in some well-known words of Michael Ramsey (later Archbishop of York and then Canterbury) in *The Gospel and the Catholic Church* (1936), which I take as an aspiration for Anglicanism rather than a description of how it is:

For while the Anglican church is vindicated by its place in history, with a strikingly balanced witness to Gospel and Church and sound learning, its greater vindication lies in its pointing through its own history to something of which it is a fragment. Its credentials are its incompleteness, with the tension and the travail in its soul. It is clumsy and untidy, it baffles neatness and logic. For it is sent not to commend itself as ‘the best type of Christianity’, but by its very brokenness to point to the universal Church.<sup>1</sup>

However, that still leaves open the possibility that Anglicans may have tended to assume that their ecclesiology was the best available and had more to commend it than the alternatives. I do not think that that assumption in itself is objectionable. Individuals could hardly be expected to give heartfelt loyalty to their particular Church unless they were convinced that it had the edge over its rivals, ecclesiologically speaking. Whatever contingent and imperfectly examined biographical and psychological factors contribute implicitly to one’s commitment to a Church, one must at least be satisfied as to its *raison d’être* – its

claims must be convincing. But it is when that theological assurance begins to generate attitudes of complacency, superiority and arrogance that repentance and apology are called for. So in suggesting that the spirit of Anglican ecclesiology is marked by a ungrudging awareness of its incompleteness, the absence of the sense of totality and finality, I mean that in an objective sense. The spirit of individual Anglicans, in the subjective sense, on the other hand, may frequently be appalling!

In speaking about the Anglican understanding of the Church, I could not confine myself to the Church of England even if I wanted to. That would be out of the question because the Church of England belongs to the worldwide Anglican Communion of Churches where it is one of many. But it is with the Church of England that I need to begin, though it is not where I will end up in this discussion. I write as an Anglican who cherishes the worldwide Communion and the friendly links that it has brought me to fellow Anglicans in many parts of the world, especially North America, the West Indies, Southern Africa, the Antipodes and the Far East, not forgetting, closer to home, Ireland, Scotland and Wales. I see myself as speaking from the mainstream of the Anglican tradition and as seeking to articulate a consensus on the Anglican understanding of the Church that will prove relevant and helpful across the Anglican Communion in all its diversity.

Until fairly recently, Anglicans in the Church of England have been able to take their church for granted. Its pedigree goes back long before the Reformation to the beginnings of Christianity in Britain and Ireland. It is still the majority Church, having baptized almost half of the population, and is expected to officiate at most funerals. It has its parish churches and its clergy in every community. It has thousands of church schools. Its history is inextricably intertwined with the history of the nation. It is recognized by the state and connected to the crown. It has its chaplains in schools, colleges, hospitals, prisons and the armed services. Its worship and ministry is woven into the very fabric of the community.

All that is still basically true and needs to be reaffirmed, but it is much less secure than it was 50 or even 15 years ago. In some parts of the nation the position of the Church of England is tenuous. Though in many villages, market towns and affluent suburbs the parish church has a central role and an effective ministry, the work is becoming harder. Even in the inner cities, the parish church is still a significant presence, but its impact on the local community is marginal.

Everywhere, however, the Church of England is under pressure from three modern phenomena that go under the catch-all names of secularization, privatization and pluralization.

The complex process that sociologists call secularization refers essentially to the diminished influence of religion in public life and in the common expressions of culture. Secularization does not necessarily mean that people generally are less religious or that prayer is not important to them, or that they do not hold beliefs about sacred or transcendent meanings and values. But it points to the evident fact that religious beliefs and religious authorities no longer figure prominently in many public institutions, such as Parliament or the universities, or in most expressions of cultural life, such as the mass media.

Secularization is related to privatization, which refers to the way that religious beliefs, practices and values, marginalized in public discourse and community activities, are increasingly relegated to the personal and domestic contexts. Religious beliefs and commitments are not thought suitable candidates for public affirmation. They are regarded as a private matter. Public figures very rarely 'do God'. But family life in very many cases is not robust enough to sustain religious faith and practice. So religion misses out on both fronts. For the Christian, one's faith can never be a purely private matter: personal, yes; private, no. The kingdom of God claims allegiance over every part of life, including public life, and God's mission knows no boundaries.

Let me take an example of secularization and privatization that will be familiar to every adult in England and Wales. The decoupling some years ago of the Christian festival of Pentecost (Whitsun) from the Spring bank holiday (Whit Monday) and the resulting confusion in the minds even of churchgoers as to the date of Pentecost is a token of this process. The outcome is that Pentecost has become a second-class festival for the Church, which then has to work all the harder to make it meaningful. This example illustrates how practising Christians are increasingly not assisted by public institutions to observe their faith (this is an aspect of secularization), but are compelled to observe it in their own time and for their own motives (this is the essence of privatization).

Alongside secularization stands the process (much more long term) of pluralization. It is true that there has never been a time (certainly not since the Reformation, nearly half a millennium ago) when the Church of England had an absolute monopoly of the religious belief and practice of the population. There

were always communities who did not identify with the national Church: in Elizabeth I's reign, recusant Roman Catholics and a tiny minority of so-called Separatists; a century later, Quakers and Jews; since 1662, substantial communities of Nonconformists as well as Roman Catholics. The theory was, however, that all members of the community ('commonwealth') were or should be members of the Church of England, and this principle underpinned the Church's involvement in local, regional and national government, education, health care and supervision of moral behaviour.

Today, on the other hand, Anglicans in England are one faith community among others. We may be the largest in terms of nominal membership, but we are not dominant. Our beliefs and values have to compete in the marketplace of faiths, which includes non-Christian religions, notably Islam and Hinduism, as well as other Christian communities such as the Roman Catholics, Methodists, Orthodox and Baptists, and with aggressive secularism and atheism. While the relationship between the Churches is generally excellent and practical co-operation is strong, the existence of a plurality of faiths has the effect of relativizing the claims of each: as one option among many, no one of them has a *prima facie* claim to credibility.<sup>2</sup>

The related processes of secularization, privatization and pluralization mean that as English Anglicans we can no longer take our Church for granted. Its claims and position in society are not assured any more. We know that our message will not be heard, our ministry will not be received, our values will not survive, unless we grasp the challenge of mission and evangelization with both hands. The competitive situation in which as Anglicans in England we now find ourselves means that we cannot assume that people both inside and outside the Church know what we stand for. Often they have the haziest and craziest ideas about the Churches and the Christian faith.

On the whole we are not winning the battle. In spite of much spiritual vitality in parts of the Church of England and imaginative mission initiatives, known as 'fresh expressions', decline is the order of the day. The drift is steadily downwards. The presence and impact of the Church of England and of all Christian Churches is steadily being eroded, even in their heartlands. That is not a counsel of despair, but a rallying cry to meet the challenge. To do so we need several things: effective leadership, a laity galvanized for mission, clergy who will reinvent themselves as apostles to the unchurched, attractive worship and persuasive apologetics. But even all those things, if we had them throughout the

length and breadth of the Church, would not be enough unless they were held within a framework of good theology. What we need, among other things, is a firm theological grasp of our message, our ministry and our values.<sup>3</sup>

So far I have talked only about the Church of England. I needed to start from that point. But Anglicanism is a worldwide expression of the Christian Church. The other – approximately 40 – member Churches of the Anglican Communion (for ecclesiological reasons, I prefer to speak about ‘member Churches’ rather than ‘provinces’) are already familiar with the challenges that the Church of England is beginning to face. Their circumstances have generally been rather different from those of the Church of England. They are not usually majority Churches. They are not usually established by law. They do not, in most cases, have many centuries of history behind them. They are not, generally speaking, territorial Churches in the same way as the Church of England is, with its parochial structure going back to Anglo-Saxon times. Many do not have substantial inherited resources to help finance their mission. Most Anglican Churches have always had to pay their way and fight their corner. They are more aware than we English Anglicans are of the need to know what we stand for, to be aware of what is distinctive about our doctrine of the Church. This introduction is meant for them too.

But there is another factor that challenges us to grapple with the doctrine of the Church and the Anglican tradition of interpreting that doctrine. Anglican self-awareness has been raised further by the ecumenical movement. As Christians from different traditions have come together in theological dialogue and practical co-operation – as centuries of suspicion and alienation have been broken down – they have all been compelled to ask: What do we stand for? How is our view of the Church distinctive? Where do we disagree with others? Where do our basic beliefs come from? Who decides and on what authority? Possibly, this kind of ecumenical engagement has proved more of a challenge to Anglicans than to members of some other traditions. In this way we become acutely aware that we need an Anglican ecclesiology. Our next task, then, is to explain this technical term ‘ecclesiology’.

## **Questions for reflection and discussion**

Why is theology important to the identity and mission of Anglicanism?

What are the symptoms of institutional decline in the member church of the Anglican Communion to which you belong and what are the signals of vitality?

### **For further reading**

Avis, Paul, *Church, State and Establishment*, London: SPCK, 2001.

Avis, Paul, *A Church Drawing Near: Spirituality and Mission in a Post-Christian Culture*, London and New York: T&T Clark, 2003.

Davie, Grace, *Religion in Britain Since 1945: Believing without Belonging*, Oxford: Blackwell, 1994 (new edition forthcoming).

Percy, Martyn, *Shaping the Church: The Promise of Implicit Theology*, Farnham, Surrey and Burlington, VT: Ashgate, 2010.

Sykes, Stephen, Booty, John and Knight, Jonathan (eds), *The Study of Anglicanism*, 2nd edn, London: SPCK, 1998.

Wells, Samuel, *What Anglicans Believe: An Introduction*, London: Canterbury Press, 2011.

## Why do Christians need to understand the Church?

Ecclesiology is the theological study of the Christian Church. Ecclesiology focuses on the Church as it appears in Scripture and in historical theology. It studies the Church of today in all its diversity, and it looks to how the Church should develop in the light of the challenges that it faces – the past, present and future of the Church. The word ‘ecclesiology’ is made up of the Greek ekklesia (assembly) and logos (discourse), to stand for ordered speech about the Church (just as the word ‘theology’ is made up of the Greek theos (god or God) and logos (discourse), to stand for ordered speech about God and the things of God. We meet the Greek term logos most familiarly in the Prologue to St John’s Gospel: ‘In the beginning was the word (logos) ...’

In its original meaning ekklesia is a secular term for an assembly of people and is derived from the verb to call (together). It was employed by those who translated the Old Testament (the Jewish Bible) from Hebrew into Greek before the coming of Christ. This version, known as the Septuagint (LXX), used ekklesia to translate the Hebrew qahal (assembly), which in turn derives from the Hebrew for voice (qol). Incidentally, the Septuagint also used sunagoge (cf. synagogue) to translate qahal. In both Hebrew and Greek, then, the words used to stand for the church mean the assembly of those who are called – called together to worship God, or called out of the world, to serve God. It is worth noting in passing, however, that the English word ‘church’ comes from a different source: the Greek kuriake, ‘belonging to the Lord (kurios)’ (cf. the Scottish ‘kirk’). Originally referring to the building, ‘the church’ has come to mean the people and the institution as well.

To be faithful to the meaning of ekklesia, it should always have the definite article: ‘the Church’. The current trend to speak of ‘church’ in a generic sense moves away from the clear sense of Scripture and Christian doctrine that there is one Church, called in the purposes of God, founded by Jesus Christ through his Incarnation, life, ministry, death, resurrection, Ascension and outpouring of the Holy Spirit. There is one Church to which we are required to belong and that we

are called to serve. The term ‘church’ without the definite article, as in ‘doing church’, ‘being church’ and so on, has the merit of suggesting that the Church is a dynamic thing, always in motion, ever active, but it has the fatal demerit of implying, perhaps inadvertently, that the Church is something that we can make or do or bring into being, that it revolves around human activity, rather than divine institution and divine initiative. Christians should always speak of ‘the Church’, the one, holy, catholic and apostolic Church of Jesus Christ.

The transition from the secular meaning ‘assembly’ to the Christian meaning ‘church’ in the theological sense is found in the New Testament. Ekklesia is found in only one of the Gospels (Matthew), where it occurs three times. On two occasions it still has its basic meaning of ‘assembly’ (Matthew 18.17: ‘tell it to the church’), but the third instance has the broader sense: ‘on this rock I will build my church’ (Matthew 16.18).

In the Epistles, ekklesia occurs frequently and three uses can be discerned.

First, there is the local Christian assembly or community: ‘All the churches of Christ greet you,’ writes Paul, apparently referring with some exaggeration to the scattered congregations in the various cities and towns of the Roman Empire where he had planted churches during his missionary journeys, together with (presumably) other congregations founded by other apostles, with whom they were in contact (Romans 16.16).

Second, there is the Church in general, the Church in a generic sense. ‘I was violently persecuting the church of God’, Paul confesses (Galatians 1.13), meaning the Church conceived as a single entity, wherever it may be found. Through his encounter with Christ on the Damascus road (‘Why are you persecuting me?’), Saul (as he then was) had come to identify the community of Christians in Damascus with the totality of Christians, organized into dispersed communities.

Third, there emerges in the later Pauline and pseudo-Pauline epistles a mystical or cosmic sense of ekklesia as the body of which Christ is the head (Colossians 1.18: ‘He is the head of the body, the church’; Ephesians 1.22–23: ‘the church, which is his body, the fullness of him who fills all in all’). This usage seems to

transcend the individual local congregations and even the whole Church on earth. It lends itself to a sense of the Church united in heaven and earth, the Church triumphant and the Church militant. It is this third sense that approximates most closely to the affirmation of the Niceno-Constantinopolitan Creed (the one used at the Eucharist): 'I believe in ... one, holy, catholic and apostolic Church.'

Hans Küng, a leading Roman Catholic theologian of the second half of the twentieth century, speaks of ecclesiology as the theological expression of the Church's image. The New Catholic Encyclopedia defines ecclesiology in a nuanced way as 'the branch of theology that seeks to give a scientific exposition of the faith of the Church concerning itself'. Ecclesiology may be defined, therefore, as reasoned and informed reflection on the nature of the Christian Church, understood theologically, that is to say in the light of God's revealed nature and purpose.

Ecclesiology has a number of departments or sub-divisions. Pastoral or practical theology, together with the theology of the ministry and sacraments, worship and liturgy, deals with how our understanding of the Church is put into practice in specific contexts, in those activities that are intrinsic to the Church's nature: ministry and worship. Conciliarity and polity, which concern structures of authority, decision-making and governance, are essentially ecclesiological matters. Ecumenical theology is a major area of ecclesiology since a great deal of theological reflection on the Church transcends particular traditions (though we can never get out of our own skin completely) and ecumenical theological dialogue has generally focused on the Church and has given enormous impetus to ecclesiology. Ecclesiology is perhaps most closely related to missiology, since the Church exists only in the activity of mission. And since the Church's actions cannot be arbitrary, but need to be guided by norms, ecclesiology is also closely connected to the study of canon law, the rules of the Church.

Although ecclesiology clearly has a practical dimension and is nothing if it is not applied to the life of the Church, it is essentially a branch of Christian doctrine, concerned with what we believe as Christians about the Church and God's purpose for it and how that purpose is to be carried out in accordance with God's will revealed in Scripture as interpreted in the light of tradition and reason. But

that does not make ecclesiology a purely theoretical discipline: it is not merely descriptive but has an inescapably prescriptive function. Ultimately it aims to say what the Church should be like and how it should carry out its mission. Ecclesiology needs to become concrete. Ecumenical reports are sometimes criticized for being too idealistic and there is some truth in this, but it is one of the tasks of ecclesiology to show us the Church as it should be: 'This is the Church.' Ecclesiology, like theology as a whole, is normally undertaken from a position of Christian belief, informed by commitment to the Christian Church and sustained by prayer and sacrament. As in all theology, we are totally dependent on God: 'O send out your light and your truth; let them lead me' (Psalm 43.3).

Ecclesiology must then have a prophetic, critical dimension. It will not merely celebrate the Church's past and present glories (if at all), but will also sit in judgement on the failings and shortcomings of the Church in history and in the present. In this part of its work, ecclesiology will draw not only on 'internal' sources of critique, such as the biblical prophetic books and the major reforming insights of historical theology (such as the Protestant Reformation of the sixteenth century and the theological renewal around the Second Vatican Council of the Roman Catholic Church, 1962–65), but also on historical and sociological studies of the Church as an empirical, worldly phenomenon that can be studied by secular disciplines.

Ecclesiology can also learn from secular traditions of critique, especially ideological criticism in the broadly Marxist tradition that helps to uncover the legitimization in ideas of material vested interests and oppressive distributions of power (for which critique the Christian Church is an obvious candidate). Ecclesiology needs to combine what Paul Ricoeur has called the hermeneutic of suspicion and the hermeneutic of restoration, critique and construction.

Issues of authority, leadership, government and discipline particularly invite analysis and comment from the social sciences, and ecclesiology cannot afford to ignore their contribution, even though their comparative, relativistic and critical approach may seem threatening. Some classical ecclesiologies (Roman Catholic, Orthodox, Anglican or Protestant) claim that the nature of the Church, including its structures of government or oversight, its outward political aspect or polity (papal, episcopalian, presbyterian or congregational) is given by God in divine revelation and is not subject to the judgement of human reason; in other words, they absolutize a particular form or shape of the Church. They tend to

assert that the ultimate integrity of the Church is guaranteed by divine providence, so that the vicissitudes of Christian history become retrospectively baptized as the unfolding of a divine purpose. The Roman Catholic Church officially holds that its teaching is not shaped by contingent cultural factors and that its papal and episcopal structure is ordained by God through Jesus' commissioning of Peter and the other eleven apostles.

Similarly, some modern theologians in the tradition of Karl Barth (d. 1968) – John Milbank being a notable contemporary example – regard the social sciences as tendentious and reductionist in relation to Christian theology, rather than as offering ideologically neutral conceptual tools to help us to understand the Church. They see no place for scrutinizing the Church and its structures by merely human methods that are not subordinated to divine revelation in Scripture. This scepticism with regard to the precisely ideological motives of ideological criticism itself is well taken, but any suggestion that the truth of God can be discerned and known in abstraction and isolation from cultural and socio-economic influences is no less ideologically naive. Christian truth is embedded in contingent human and social realities. Rare are the theologians, such as the great Protestant theologian F. D. E. Schleiermacher in the early nineteenth century, who can accept that the outward face of the Church in history (its political aspect, so to speak) is largely contingent, but nevertheless hold that that fact does not detract from the abiding validity of the inward essence of Christianity. However, once we accept, in continuity with the dynamic of the Reformation, which saw the Church as continually reforming itself (*Ecclesia reformata semper reformanda*), that the critique of Christianity belongs to the very essence of Christianity, a vigilant welcome is assured for the commentary offered by the social sciences.

The aspects of ideological critique that are particularly relevant to ecclesiology concern the distribution of power and the exercise of authority in the Church. This theme comes into focus in several areas: the bearing of particular political models: centralized and hierarchical (monarchical), or dispersed and consultative (conciliar), on church government; the relation of Church and state; the models of authority that pertain in the Church (traditional, bureaucratic or charismatic, to use the sociologist Max Weber's well-known typology); the ideological investment that established institutions make in the formulation and enforcement of official teaching ('dogma'), which inevitably reflects sectional interests and refracts and distorts the interpretation of divine revelation; and the unmasking of gender bias and prejudice (sexism, androcentrism and patriarchy) in the Church

in the light of feminist critiques.

Social science critique is not the only factor militating against the grandiose, absolutist and authoritarian ecclesiologies of the past (and present). These were often dependent on equally grandiose, absolutist and authoritarian forms of 'secular' political structure. Traditionally, Christianity has tended to uphold, both in its teaching and its discipline, the ideal of unanimity of belief and uniformity of practice (expressed, for example, in the various Acts of Uniformity that feature in English religious history up to modern times). These ideals were thought to be demanded ultimately by the unity of God, reflected in the unity of the Church. This aspiration belies the reality of diversity and conflict in the Church from New Testament times to the present day. The pluralism of faith and practice in the Church today mirrors the pluralism in society at large.

Theological pluralism is a product not only of the creative fertility of the theological imagination, working on the resources of revelation in Scripture and tradition, but also of the diversity of social, economic and cultural settings in which theology is carried on, from advanced capitalist western societies with their dissolving sense of community and tradition, to emerging Asian and African countries with their clash of the old traditional, stable patterns and the new corrosive demands of industrialization and technology. The pluralism of theology today is also a function of theology's response to new intellectual challenges to Christian belief, particularly from the world of the physical, human and medical sciences.

Recent theology has begun to make a virtue of necessity and to seek a theological rationale for theological pluralism. In ecumenical theology and practice, the fact that there is a plurality of churches, beliefs and forms of worship and government is taken as axiomatic and does not seem to trouble us – which is a measure of the sea-change that occurred in theology in the twentieth century. The fact that there are many thousands of Christian denominations does not sit easily with intolerant and absolutist claims for one's own position (though the sense of perspective and the humility perhaps thereby induced should not be equated with the extreme dogmatic relativism that has abandoned the quest for attainable truth).

Ecclesiology assumes greater urgency in times of conflict or renewal in the Church as old beliefs and structures are placed under strain. The Reformation, the Enlightenment and the French Revolution put Roman Catholic ecclesiology on the defensive until the Second Vatican Council, and to many observers it

seems to be in defensive mode again today. Protestant ecclesiology was reinvigorated through the influence of the religious revivals of the eighteenth century and thence through the work of F. D. E. Schleiermacher in Germany in the early nineteenth century. German Protestant theology stimulated Samuel Taylor Coleridge, Thomas Arnold and Frederick Denison Maurice to search for a renewed ecclesiology for an increasingly pluralist situation in nineteenth-century England. By the same token, High Church Anglican ecclesiology was revitalized by John Henry Newman, William Palmer and William Ewart Gladstone, among others. The ecumenical movement of the twentieth century received its impulse from the missionary expansion of the western Churches (and thus ultimately from the eighteenth- and nineteenth-century religious revivals). But this original missionary motive, while by no means lost in the ecumenical movement, became transposed into a renewal of ecclesiology in the Faith and Order movement, which became a component of the World Council of Churches at its formation in 1948.

Through ecumenical theological dialogues, bilateral and multilateral, all traditions of the Church have been compelled to reassess their self-understanding and their evaluation of other Churches. The ecumenical encounter has generated a quest for Anglican ecclesial identity within the Anglican Communion. Some Protestant Churches have begun to look again at the value of the historic episcopate in helping to realize the visible unity of the Church. Even the Eastern Orthodox, long-standing participants in the ecumenical process, are conducting something of an internal debate on the validity of their traditionally exclusive ecclesiology. But the most remarkable renewal of ecclesiology has taken place in the Roman Catholic Church, culminating in the constitution on the Church (*Lumen Gentium*) and the decree on ecumenism (*Unitatis Redintegratio*) of Vatican II. Intense theological ferment on the subject of the Church, its authority, its ministry and its ecumenical identity has continued in the Roman Catholic Church since Vatican II. However, during the pontificates of John Paul II and Benedict XVI the exercise of a strong central teaching authority (*magisterium*) has prevented this creativity from developing into a fully ecumenical policy.

To sum up this brief discussion, we can say that ecclesiology is the department of Christian theology that takes the Church's self-understanding as its object. Ecclesiology is pursued in biblical, historical, systematic and practical modes. It draws on the resources of tradition, engages with contemporary culture and dreams dreams of the future Church. Ecclesiology may be defined, therefore, as the critical study of the dominant models of the Church's self-understanding.

A basic ecclesiology is in fact an essential item for every thinking lay Christian to carry in their backpack, for we cannot be Christians at all without the Church, ‘the blessed company of all faithful people’. Therefore we need to be able to say what the Church of Christ is and how that particular branch of it to which we belong is related to the whole Church. Even more obviously, no ordained Christian minister can function without an ecclesiology: we would not know what we were doing or why, as clergy or ministers, we receive our authority for ministry from Christ through the Church. Therefore we need to know what are the theological credentials (the defining ecclesiological characteristics) of the Church that has bestowed on us the authority to minister word, sacrament and pastoral care in the name of Christ. Ecclesiology is a part of theology that no Christian, lay or ordained, can afford to neglect if their witness and ministry are to have any credibility.

### **Questions for reflection and discussion**

How does the way that we understand the Church (ecclesiology) impact on our Christian life and worship from day to day?

How has your Christian life been affected by interacting with Christians of other traditions?

### **For further reading**

Avis, Paul, *Reshaping Ecumenical Theology: The Church Made Whole?*, London and New York: T&T Clark, 2010.

Badcock, Gary D., *The House Where God Lives: Renewing the Doctrine of the Church for Today*, Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 2009.

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### The quest for Anglican ecclesiology

While Anglicans can get pretty steamed up about some topical ecclesiological issues, like women bishops, the place of homosexuals in the Church and what they thought of last Sunday's sermon, they tend not to give much thought to the Church of Jesus Christ, its faith and order and its mission in the world. Where two or three Anglicans are gathered together the most likely topic of conversation is the politics of the flower rota or the arrangements for the parish fête! However, there are some signs that Anglicans around the world are beginning to take ecclesiology more seriously than has been the case for many years.

It is entirely appropriate that there should be an Anglican ecclesiology. For within the overarching definition of ecclesiology, as the theological study of the Church of Jesus Christ, the one holy catholic and apostolic Church spoken of in the creeds, there are narrower, more domestic applications of ecclesiology where the distinctive characteristics of one particular Christian tradition are explored, expounded and criticized. Within this plurality of ecclesiologies, there must inevitably be a place for an Anglican ecclesiology.

Supposing, for the sake of argument, that as Anglicans we were to borrow all our other doctrines from elsewhere, we could not exist as a Church without at least an ecclesiology of our own. Since the Churches of the Anglican Communion, with their ministries and sacraments, are not recognized as having full ecclesial reality by the two most ancient of Christian Churches, the Roman Catholic Church and the Eastern Orthodox Churches, how would we Anglicans know that we belonged to the Christian Church without an ecclesiology that substantiated that claim? As Bishop Stephen Sykes has frequently insisted, 'It cannot be the case that there is no Anglican ecclesiology.'<sup>1</sup>

It has been well said that 'Anglicanism, since its beginnings, has been forged on the anvil of ecclesiological controversy.'<sup>2</sup> It is the doctrine of the Church (ecclesiology), rather than the doctrine of salvation (soteriology), that has been

the driving force of historic Anglicanism. Of course the two are bound up together and there cannot be one without the other. Christology and ecclesiology belong together. This is reflected in the ancient doctrine ‘No salvation outside the Church’ (*extra ecclesiam nulla salus*) – however the Church may be defined. What is meant by salvation and what is meant by Church in this dictum require considerable nuancing, but clearly the two go hand in hand. Although salvation and the Church are two sides of the same coin, there may be a difference of emphasis, on the one or the other, in particular Christian traditions.

In the case of Anglicanism, its distinctiveness has been worked out in relation to ecclesiology rather than soteriology. When we think of Anglicanism, most of us do not immediately think of the urgent need for the salvation of our souls! The picture that probably comes into our minds is not Bunyan’s Pilgrim, with his back to the City of Destruction, toiling up a steep and rugged pathway with an enormous burden of sins on his back.<sup>3</sup> It is more likely to be a homely picture of a parish church with its kindly but somewhat harassed vicar. It is, however, worth emphasizing that Anglicanism, like all the many and varied forms of Christianity, is inescapably a way of salvation. It plants our feet firmly on the path to heaven. Its liturgy, in the tradition of the Book of Common Prayer, is profoundly and seriously soteriological. It unites us to God in Christ through the Holy Spirit by means of word and sacrament, received in faith. Anglican worship arises from a heartfelt sense of human need and a thankful acceptance of the remedy provided by the grace of God.

Anglicanism is one of the humanly, historically conditioned institutional forms taken by that gracious saving action of God, through the ministry of word, sacrament and pastoral care, and our human response to it in faith and discipleship. This fact suggests that the Church is inextricably involved in the Anglican way of salvation and that we are not far out, after all, if it is the church where we worship, rather than some individualistic image of salvation, that first springs to mind when Anglicanism is mentioned. Let no one imagine that I am writing this book about the Church because I think that salvation is not important. Nothing could be further from the truth! The report of the Anglican–Roman Catholic International Commission, *Salvation and the Church*, rightly linked the two.<sup>4</sup>

Yet Anglicans have never fully agreed about what sort of Church theirs is and should be. There has been no single dominant Anglican ecclesiology. As Mark Chapman has brought out clearly, Anglican theology has always been complex

and contested.<sup>5</sup> In recent times, the pluralism of Anglican theology seems to have made thoughtful Anglicans a little cynical about ecclesiology altogether. It has been the poor relation among theological disciplines and has often been seriously neglected in theological education (in England at least), especially in the training of ordinands. Yet there are few areas of theology that are more fundamental than the study of the Church.

It is, therefore, encouraging to note that during the past decade or two, the issue of Anglican ecclesial identity has been promoted to a place near the top of the Anglican agenda. We might take the publication of Stephen Sykes' stimulating tract *The Integrity of Anglicanism* on the eve of the 1978 Lambeth Conference of all Anglican bishops as marking the beginning of the current preoccupation with Anglican identity.<sup>6</sup> But the question of Anglican ecclesial identity is not a new one. We are certainly not the first generation to be exercised by it. Lambeth Conferences, particularly those of 1930 and 1948, have provided classic statements of Anglican self-definition. This is how the 1930 Lambeth Conference defined the Anglican Communion:

The Anglican Communion is a fellowship, within the one, holy, catholic and apostolic Church, of those duly constituted dioceses, provinces, or regional Churches in communion with the see of Canterbury, which have the following characteristics in common:

they uphold and propagate the catholic and apostolic faith and order as they are generally set forth in the Book of Common Prayer as authorised in their several churches;

they are particular or national Churches, and as such, promote within each of their territories a national expression of Christian faith, life and worship; and

they are bound together not by a central legislative and executive authority but by mutual loyalty sustained by the common counsel of the bishops in conference.<sup>7</sup>

In fact, however, the concern for Anglican identity can be traced back well beyond the Lambeth Conferences, which began in the second half of the nineteenth century (1867). The problem is perennial. It is as old as Anglicanism itself, but it has surfaced particularly strongly at times of greatest stress and conflict.

In the mid-sixteenth century, John Jewel (Bishop of Salisbury and the first robust apologist for the reformed English Church) and Matthew Parker (Queen Elizabeth's first Archbishop of Canterbury) argued for the antiquity and independence of the English Church over against the Roman Catholic Church and the papacy and defended the right of a part of the Church to reform itself. At the end of the sixteenth century, Richard Hooker devoted his treatise *Of the Laws of Ecclesiastical Polity* to defining and defending the integrity of the Anglican polity against the radical Puritans within the Church of England, who believed that the Reformation was incomplete because the Church of England did not conform in all respects to the pattern of 'the best reformed churches', that is to say John Calvin's and Theodore Beza's Geneva, and sought to expel the residues of medieval catholicism in liturgy, polity and doctrine. In the mid-seventeenth century, during the aftermath of the English Civil War and the Commonwealth under Oliver Cromwell, Anglicans in exile (like John Cosin), or keeping a low profile in retirement (like Henry Hammond), devoted their efforts to reconstructing the identity of the Church of England and were given the opportunity to implement, at least partially, the blueprint that they had devised at the Restoration of the monarchy and the Church in 1660–62. In the 1830s, John Keble, John Henry Newman, Richard Hurrell Froude and Edward Bouverie Pusey sprang to the defence of a conservative (that is, politically, as well as theologically conservative) interpretation of Anglican identity in the face of the emerging pluralistic and incipiently secular state.

The issues that called forth the passionate dedication and massive scholarship of earlier Anglican divines have not yet been laid to rest: they are still very much with us. The Roman Catholic Church still claims for the papacy an immediate, ordinary, universal jurisdiction over all local churches (dioceses), infallibility for its dogmas and unquestioning obedience to its day-to-day teaching on faith and morals by what is called the ordinary magisterium (teaching office). The Anglican polity with its sacramental principle and its historic episcopate still requires justification against the radical Protestant critique of all inherited structures. The status of the Church of England as a national church, by law established, on which all citizens have a claim and which is deeply implicated in

the life of the English people, is still controversial, even though the terms of establishment have been continually modified and the pastoral situation is more strongly pluralistic than ever. The question of Anglican identity is still posed by all these factors; but there are two important new factors to be taken into account: the ecumenical movement and developments within the Anglican Communion. Let us glance at each of these.

As we have already noted, when churches take part in ecumenical dialogue that aims to clarify the differences of the past, remove unnecessary barriers to communion and seek a basis for further steps to unity, it becomes all the more vital for them to have a clear sense of their historical identity. Their representatives need an awareness of the various factors that have shaped them as particular Christian traditions (Roman Catholic, Orthodox, Anglican, Lutheran, Reformed, Methodist, Baptist, Pentecostal) and of the theological principles on which they have, historically, taken their stand. There can be little doubt that the work of the Anglican–Roman Catholic International Commission (ARCIC) and other bilateral conversations have concentrated the minds of Anglicans to reflect on their ecclesial identity. In this respect, Roman Catholic representatives have an advantage: there is clearly an enormous difference between a communion, such as the Roman Catholic Church, with its central teaching office (magisterium) and a clearly defined body of doctrine stated in a fairly cut-and-dried way in authoritative documents, on the one hand, and a communion like the Anglican Communion, on the other, that travels with fairly light doctrinal baggage, makes a virtue of dispersed authority and gives a constitutional role to laity and ordinary clergy in structures of representative church government.

The second issue that has heightened the question of Anglican identity today is the nature and future of the Anglican Communion, the worldwide family of legally autonomous or self-governing but spiritually and pastorally interdependent Churches that are in communion with the Archbishop of Canterbury. Changes in The Episcopal Church in the USA, in the direction of sexual inclusivism, and the growing numerical strength and confidence of conservative Anglican Churches in the developing world has intensified the polarizing forces within the Communion and led to conservative episcopal interventions across diocesan boundaries. At the 1998 Lambeth Conference the battlelines were drawn up between western liberals and developing-world conservatives over human sexuality. The consecration of a bishop in a same-gender union in The Episcopal Church in 2003 and the approval of the liturgical

blessing of such unions in that Church and in the Canadian Diocese of New Westminster created a crisis within the Communion. The Lambeth Commission, set up by the Archbishop of Canterbury, produced The Windsor Report in 2004.<sup>8</sup> It called for a threefold moratorium – on the consecration of gay bishops, the blessing of same-gender unions and cross-border interventions. None of these has been comprehensively observed. The other major proposal was for an Anglican Communion Covenant that would provide for consultation, mediation and, if all else failed, some sanctions (‘relational consequences’) where a member Church was proposing a development that could damage the unity of the Communion. At the time of writing, the Covenant is being considered by the member Churches and there is no time limit set for this process. It remains unclear what the Communion will look like in, say, ten years’ time.<sup>9</sup>

The different speeds at which provinces are ordaining women to the diaconate, the priesthood and the episcopate has increased the stresses. Acceptance of the notion of ‘impaired communion’ between provinces that do not any longer enjoy a full mutual recognition of ministries, because of this issue, calls into question the reality of a coherent and unified Anglican identity. The possibility then arises of a diversity of interpretations of Anglican identity emerging within the Anglican Communion. The quest for fundamental axioms of Anglican ecclesial identity, which may prove stronger than individual theological stances or differences over policy, thus acquires an added urgency.

The Preface to the Declaration of Assent in the Church of England (Canon C15), which is used whenever a person is ordained or admitted to a new ministry, is a superb statement of the Anglican understanding of the Church on the part of one of the member Churches of the Anglican Communion. Its essence has been incorporated into the proposed Covenant.

The Church of England is part of the one, holy, catholic and apostolic Church worshipping the one true God, Father, Son and Holy Spirit. It professes the faith uniquely revealed in the Holy Scriptures and set forth in the catholic creeds, which faith the Church is called upon to proclaim afresh in each generation. Led by the Holy Spirit, it has borne witness to Christian truth in its historic formularies, the Thirty-nine Articles of Religion, the Book of Common Prayer, and the Ordering of Bishops, Priests and Deacons.

## **Questions for reflection and discussion**

How has your own Anglican church been shaped by its history and the surrounding society and culture?

Would it matter if the Anglican Communion were to fall apart, and why?

## **For further reading**

Avis, Paul, *The Identity of Anglicanism: Essentials of Anglican Ecclesiology*, London and New York: T&T Clark, 2008.

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### Three models of Anglican self-understanding

Not all Anglicans have understood their Church in the same way and there is far from being unanimity today about the ecclesiological identity of Anglicanism. The three main traditions of ‘churchmanship’ within Anglicanism each has its own slant on its identity: the evangelical and/or Reformed, the Anglican catholic and/or traditionalist, and the liberal and/or broad church traditions. The difficulty in finding the right form of words to describe these groups points to the fact that each one contains considerable diversity. Not all evangelicals are Reformed in the sense of Calvinistic theology. Not all Anglican catholics are traditionalists in that they oppose the ordination of women to the priesthood and the episcopate – far from it. Liberalism is not confined to the broad church sector: there are liberal evangelicals and liberal catholics also. Though Anglican charismatics are most likely to be found among evangelicals, the charismatic movement has touched all parts of the Anglican family, bringing greater spontaneity in worship, renewal in spirituality and confidence in the power of the Holy Spirit. These ‘party’ labels are crude and can be misleading, but taken overall they point to various strands of Anglican self-definition.

When we look at the Anglican understanding of the Church in historical perspective, we can discern three dominant models or paradigms of Anglican identity or self-understanding. Though these must be seen as crude generalizations and even caricatures, they do shed some light on Anglican self-definition in history and today. Let us consider them in turn.

#### **The nation-as-church model**

The nation-as-church model of Anglicanism held sway for three centuries, from

the Reformation to the Oxford Movement. I have called this elsewhere the ‘Erastian paradigm’ – Erastianism being the theory of ecclesiastical government that gives the state a significant role in spiritual oversight, especially in applying sanctions, including excommunication.<sup>1</sup> If we want a slogan for this model, it might be ‘The citizen as Anglican’. Church and people, Christians and citizens, were regarded as one entity in a Christian commonwealth. Church and nation were coterminous. To be English was to be Anglican. All those born into the English nation were baptized into the English Church. You did not opt in and, in the sixteenth century at least, you could not opt out. The nation-as-church model was the presupposition of the Anglican Reformers, Richard Hooker and the seventeenth-century Caroline divines. It was still fundamental to the ecclesiology of the Tractarians two hundred years later, though they gave it a different twist, as we shall see, and was equally important to the ‘Broad Church’ theologians: Samuel Taylor Coleridge, Thomas Arnold and Frederick Denison Maurice.

These Anglican theologians did not, of course, deny that there was only one Church and that it was a visible Church. But for practical purposes they thought of it as constituted by ‘particular’ or national Churches. Only by emphasizing the integrity of particular Churches over against the claim of Rome to immediate universal jurisdiction could they have succeeded in defending the Reformation of the Church. The nation-as-church model of Anglican identity was enforced by successive acts of uniformity and by legal penalties against dissenters (Roman Catholic or Protestant). The legal framework was progressively relaxed from 1689 and was repealed on the eve of the Oxford Movement (the late 1820s and early 1830s), so precipitating a crisis of Anglican identity.

The sovereign was ‘Supreme Governor’ of the national Church, not to perform sacramental ministry or (less certainly) to define doctrine, but to have the ultimate oversight of all subjects in spiritual as well as temporal matters (it would be anachronistic to say ‘secular’). Though a lay person, the sovereign was anointed at his or her coronation (and still is), thus becoming a sacred figure, a symbol of the identity of the national Church, pledged by the coronation oath to watch over and defend the privileges of the Church.

At the accession of King Charles I in 1625, William Laud preached at the Chapel Royal, Whitehall. ‘The King’, he declared, ‘is God’s immediate lieutenant upon earth, and the power which resides in the King is not any assuming to himself, nor any gift from the people, but God’s.’ Church and state, according to the

injunctions issued by authority of Charles I in 1626, but drafted by Laud, 'are so nearly united together that they may seem to be two bodies, yet in some relations they may be accounted but as one in as much as they are both made up of the same men which are differentiated only in relation to spiritual and civil ends'.<sup>2</sup>

As the throne began to totter, the rhetoric of divine right, underpinning the unity of Church and state, became the more shrill. In 1640 Convocation declared:

The most high and sacred order of kings is of divine right being the ordinance of God himself, founded in the prime laws of nature, and clearly established by express texts both of the Old and New Testaments. A supreme power is given to this most excellent order by God himself in the Scripture, which is that kings should rule and command in their several dominions all persons of what rank or estate soever, whether ecclesiastical or civil.<sup>3</sup>

Parliament, with bishops in the House of Lords, was regarded as the synod of the Church, with the Convocations of clergy in the provinces of Canterbury and York as a check, and Parliament was indeed given authority in doctrine and worship.

All this is obviously not quite how English Anglicans think of their Church today and it is a far cry from the Anglicanism of other provinces of the worldwide Communion. Can we attempt to trace some of the factors that led to the demise of the nation-as-church model of Anglican identity?

Pluralistic and centrifugal forces in English society could not be contained by the legal framework. The Civil War took the lid off the ferment and gave Presbyterians, Independents (Congregationalists) and more radical spirits their opportunity. Nonconformity became a major force in English society by the early nineteenth century.

Parliament ceased to have credibility as the synod of the Church of England as Protestant Nonconformists, Roman Catholics and even non-Christians were

admitted during the course of the nineteenth century. The demand for the Church of England to have its own legislative structure became irresistible, culminating in the Enabling Act of 1919, the foundation of today's synodical government, which began in 1970.

A succession of monarchs from the seventeenth to the nineteenth centuries seemed to fail the Church of England. As protectors of that Church's privileges and as Defenders of the Faith, they proved to be broken reeds. Charles I alienated a large proportion of the population by his religious and political policies. Charles II was a crypto-Roman Catholic and James II was overtly Roman. Both sought to undermine the Anglican monopoly by bringing forward toleration measures that, by aiding all Dissenters, would assist Roman Catholics at a time when England was under threat from major Roman Catholic powers on the Continent of Europe. When James II was compelled to vacate the throne, he was succeeded by a Calvinist Dutchman, William of Orange. George I, William's successor, was likewise no Anglican, but a Lutheran from Hanover. William IV had given his royal assent to the Whig legislation in the late 1820s and early 1830s that deprived the Church of England of wealth, monopolies and privileges, culminating in the suppression of a number of scandalously superfluous Irish bishoprics and archbishoprics, which traditional High Churchmen like John Keble took as the crowning insult.

In England some significant traces remain of the nation-as-church model. The law of the Church is part of the law of the land. The sovereign is still the lay supreme governor of the Church (though the monarchy has become constitutional in relation to the Church just as it has in relation to Parliament). The Prime Minister still plays a role in the appointment of bishops and deans of cathedrals, regardless of his or her own Christian affiliation, or lack of it, though the General Synod's Crown Nominations Commission comes up with the names of bishops. Parliament still functions as a longstop on ecclesiastical legislation emanating from the General Synod. Some bishops still have seats in the House of Lords. Substantial civic recognition is given to the Anglican clergy and the law of the land imposes pastoral obligations on them. Common religion (the inchoate religious beliefs and values of the unchurched) provides the clergy with many opportunities of pastoral ministry. The parish structure can only be justified in terms of a national Church in which every citizen has both rights and

duties vis-à-vis the Church. The inherited resources of the Church of England, its endowments, belong within the framework of a national, established Church and would seem to entail an obligation for the Church and its clergy to make their ministry of word, sacrament and pastoral care available to all.

These particular conditions do not pertain elsewhere in the Anglican Communion, but the national Church model persists wherever Anglicans outside England see themselves as having a mission to the whole community and to the nation, as they generally do, and rightly so.<sup>4</sup>

### **The apostolic succession model**

The apostolic succession model, which elsewhere I have called the ‘apostolic paradigm’, emerged in the late seventeenth century at the Restoration of the monarchy and the liturgy and episcopate of the Church of England.<sup>5</sup> It was at this juncture that an important shift in the centre of gravity of the Church of England took place. From being an episcopal church, in which bishops were regarded as an ancient and even apostolic form of church government and were, moreover, endorsed by the civil authority (‘the magistrate’), the Church of England became, so to speak, a self-consciously ‘episcopalian’ church in which episcopacy was regarded as the only God-given, scripturally warranted ecclesiastical polity. After the Restoration, the threefold ministry in historical succession became part of the foundational ideology of Anglicanism. However, the ecumenical consequences of this model only became fully developed in the attempt of the more extreme members of the Oxford Movement to ‘unprotestantize’ the Church of England. The sacred symbol of this model is not the sovereign but the bishop. Its slogan is ‘Bishops are essential’ – essential, that is, to the very existence (the *esse*) of the Church.

The transition from the nation-as-church model to the apostolic succession model was a gradual one, suddenly accelerated at the time of the Oxford Movement. In the seventeenth century it was widely acknowledged that bishops and kings stood or fell together. As James I famously put it, ‘No Bishop, no King’. At the Civil War, his words were fulfilled when Archbishop Laud preceded King Charles I to the scaffold. Bishops and kings were equally sacred

figures clothed with divine office. The sovereign appointed and invested bishops, while bishops, for their part, crowned the sovereign, attended at court and held high positions of state. But, as we have seen, the kings one after another seemed to fail the Church. The bishops were left to fight for its claims unsupported by the Crown.

In the Oxford Movement, the figure of the bishop emerged as an alternative sacred symbol to that of the sovereign. The Tractarians looked to the episcopate to save the Church from the depredations of the Whig government. In the first of the Tracts for the Times (1833), John Henry Newman urged the bishops, ‘Magnify your office!’ He recalled them to the example of the early Fathers who had sealed their testimony with their blood. Newman wrote that he could not wish the bishops a more blessed termination of their earthly course than the spoiling of their goods and a glorious martyrdom. This was not what most prelates of the Church of England by law established, under King William IV, were hoping for!

In the fourth of the Tracts, John Keble reinforced the message. Only episcopally ordained clergy, incorporated within the apostolic succession, had the means of saving grace – efficacious sacraments – to dispense. Therefore it was only within the Church of England that salvation could be assured to English people, large numbers of whom were by now Nonconformist. This insistence became the keynote of the catholic revival in Anglicanism. The identity of Anglicanism was to be found in its episcopal orders within the apostolic succession. Now while this gave a vital bond, at least in theory, with other episcopal traditions (that is, the Roman Catholic and Eastern Orthodox Churches), it effectively cut Anglicanism off from Protestant bodies (which the Tractarians did not recognize as having all the attributes of Christian Churches).

To what extent is the fully fledged apostolic succession model a live option today? The fact is that it began to fail as soon as thought of. Newman came to see it as merely a paper theory. He and his colleagues in the radical wing of the Oxford Movement actually contributed to its demise. The clergy of the catholic revival exalted bishops in theory, but proved thorns in their flesh in practice. The bishops themselves were reluctant to conform to the role that the Tractarians assigned them. When the then bishop of Oxford (Bagot) distanced himself from the teaching of the Tracts, Newman was dismayed and his search for an alternative can be traced to that experience of rejection. When Tract 90 (in which Newman had attempted to reconcile the Thirty-Nine Articles with the decrees of

the Counter-Reformation Council of Trent) was condemned in 1841, the consequences for Newman personally were catastrophic: his alienation from the Church of his baptism was complete.<sup>6</sup> In the Ritualist Movement that emerged from the later Tractarian tradition, the notion of canonical obedience to one's bishop became highly precarious. The apostolic model failed in practice, but it failed in theory too. Its theological inadequacy can be summarized under several points.

First, it could not deliver all the essential credal notes of the Church (one, holy, catholic and apostolic). It seemed to guarantee apostolicity (the continuity of the Church with the apostles) but not catholicity (the communion of local churches with the universal Church today). Through the historic episcopal succession, a church could feel itself in communion with the Church of the apostles and early Fathers. But that in itself did nothing to bring that church into communion with the rest of episcopal Christianity. In Newman's case, this meant the Church of Rome, for Newman spared little thought for the significance of the Orthodox Churches. So Newman was led to postulate what we might call an alternative apostolic succession – not merely one of the tactile transmission of holy order, but one of continuity of ethos, of spirit with the Christians of the early Church: simple, ignorant, superstitious, persecuted and poor as they were (that was their glory in Newman's eyes). Where would the early Fathers worship if they lived today? Newman asked himself. Not in a respectable Anglican parish church, nor in one of its grand cathedrals. Athanasius and Ambrose would be found kneeling before the sacrament in the Roman Catholic mission downtown. Newman's most passionate longing was to know himself to be united to those saints and scholars of the Church when it was still one and holy. And in this way he believed that he had achieved catholicity too.<sup>7</sup>

Second, the apostolic paradigm of Anglicanism was ecumenically sterile. It did little to facilitate steps to unity. Rome did not (and does not) recognize Anglican holy orders or celebrations of the Eucharist (not even Anglican baptisms then). Rome certainly did not (and does not) accept the apostolic model of Anglican identity. In the Roman Catholic system, the episcopate has no authority apart from its communion with and obedience to the pope (which Roman Catholic theology expresses in the term 'hierarchical communion'). Moreover, this paradigm naturally did nothing to encourage any movement towards the Churches of the Reformation. If the apostolic succession was the *sine qua non* of the Church, non-episcopal bodies were not even in the picture. Progress towards church unity, which has involved Anglicans (from the Church of South India

scheme of 1947 to the Porvoo Agreement between the British and Irish Anglican Churches and the Nordic and Baltic Lutheran Churches of 1996), has involved compromising this model of Anglican ecclesial identity in its absolute form.

Furthermore, the apostolic succession model made the historic episcopate essential to the very existence (the *esse*) of the Church (something that the Anglican formularies and the generality of Anglican divines specifically refrained from doing). The Lambeth Conference of 1930 stated: ‘While we thus stand for the historic episcopate as a necessary element in any union in which the Anglican Church can take part ... we do not require of others acceptance of those reasons, or of any particular theory or interpretation of the episcopate as a condition of reunion.’ The apostolic paradigm in effect excommunicated large portions of Christendom that lacked the historic succession and, in its strong form, denied them any assurance of salvation as they lacked the divinely appointed means of grace. By seeking what the twentieth-century Reformed theologian Karl Barth called historical and empirical guarantees of the credal apostolicity of the Church, it undoubtedly quenched the Spirit in unity matters.

Ecumenical theology today has a broader understanding of the apostolicity of the Church. It sees it as carried not only by the episcopate, not even only by the ordained ministry, but by faithful continuance in the permanent attributes of the Church of the apostles across a range of tasks that together comprise the mission of the Church.<sup>8</sup> Ecumenical theology would hesitate to speak of the apostolic ministry until it has affirmed the apostolic community within which that ministry is placed and which it both serves and represents. Within that framework of the apostolicity of the whole Church and of the several means by which it is sustained and transmitted, Anglicans give the historic episcopate a place of great importance, as a sign (though not a guarantee) of the apostolicity of the Church. Anglicans do not say, and have never said officially, that a church without bishops in historic succession is not a church, but Anglicans believe that bishops are part of God’s will for the Church, because they are in certain respects successors of the apostles, and that episcopacy is therefore necessary for the visible unity of the Church.

### **The communion model**

The communion model of the Anglican understanding of the Church owes much to the ecumenical movement and particularly to developments in Roman Catholic theology. Its key concept is the Greek New Testament word *koinonia* (Latin *communio*), which is usually translated in our English Bibles as ‘communion’, ‘fellowship’, ‘sharing’ or ‘partnership’. *Koinonia* is connected in the New Testament with apostolic doctrine (Acts 2.42), the Lord’s Supper (1 Corinthians 10.16), practical support in mission (Philippians 1.5), the presence of the Holy Spirit (2 Corinthians 13.13) and solidarity with God and one’s fellow Christians (1 John 1.3). Putting the communion model in slogan terms, we could say, ‘Baptism is the basis and the Eucharist is the fulfilment.’ Baptism is the basis of our unity in Christ and brings a certain degree of communion. But the Eucharist is, as the Second Vatican Council put it, the source and summit of the Christian life.<sup>9</sup>

The communion model probes deeply into the living reality of the Church. It begins by asking, ‘What makes the Church the Church?’ It attempts to bring to light, and to subject to theological reflection, the inner spiritual vitality of the Christian community. It takes its starting point from the true basics of the gospel: the baptism of Jesus as the inauguration of his mission and as endowing him with his corporate messianic identity; and corresponding to that, the initiation of his disciples, then and now, into his Body through his Spirit in the sacrament of repentance, faith and union with Christ. The communion model takes as a key text 1 Corinthians 12.13: ‘In the one Spirit we were all baptized into one body.’ This approach brings out the immense ecclesiological significance of baptism as the instrument of our incorporation into Christ’s messianic office as our Prophet, Priest and King, an incorporation that qualifies us to carry out prophetic, priestly and royal functions in the Church.

The communion model, with its deep sacramentality, is strongly foreshadowed in the official Anglican formularies and the Anglican theological tradition, from the Thirty-Nine Articles to the Lambeth Conferences and from Richard Hooker to Frederick Denison Maurice to Michael Ramsey. The classical Anglican divines typically insisted that the fundamentals of the faith, which are required for salvation and professed in baptism, are the only proper basis of ecclesial communion. In the seventeenth century Edward Stillingfleet claimed that the unity of the Church could only be attained when she made the foundation of her being the ground of her communion. F. D. Maurice reaffirms this principle when he insists that ‘the language that makes Christ known to us is the only language which can fitly make the Church known to us’.<sup>10</sup> The Lambeth Conferences have

consistently proclaimed that it is baptism, with its accompanying baptismal faith, that makes us Christians and members of the Church, but they have gone on to urge Anglicans and indeed all Christians to seek full visible unity, expressed in a common Eucharist celebrated by a common ministry.

Baptism does not stand alone; it contains a momentum that leads us on through the stages of Christian initiation (baptism, catechesis, confirmation, communion) to the Eucharist and to our first communion (though the order of events can vary a bit).<sup>11</sup> Baptism and the Eucharist should not be separated: they are both regarded as ‘dominical’ sacraments, that is, sacraments explicitly instituted by the Lord. Modern ecumenical theology has come to see (in the words of the twentieth-century Roman Catholic theologian Henri de Lubac) that ‘the Eucharist makes the Church’, just as ‘the Church makes the Eucharist’. If baptism is the foundation of the Church and of the individual Christian life, it is the Eucharist, and within it Holy Communion, that builds the Church and strengthens us in our Christian discipleship. So alongside a baptismal ecclesiology that highlights the significance of Christian initiation, we need a eucharistic ecclesiology that brings out the importance of sacramental communion.<sup>12</sup>

Furthermore, the sacraments do not exist without the word. From another point of view, one associated with the sixteenth-century Reformers and Karl Barth, it is primarily the word of God that creates and builds the Church. In truth, word and sacrament are inseparable and mutually constitutive. The celebration of the sacraments always includes the ministry of the word, in the form of Scripture readings and a homily or sermon. In fact the theological definition of a sacrament states that the word gives ‘form’ to the ‘matter’ (the elements of water, bread and wine), making their significance clear. Word and sacrament go hand in hand and are accompanied and administered by those entrusted with pastoral responsibility (episkope). That is why Anglicans (and other Christians) cannot be satisfied until the unity of the Church, grounded in baptism and the baptismal faith, reaches fulfilment in one Eucharist celebrated by a mutually recognized and interchangeable ministry. To see the importance of baptism as binding us together in the body of Christ is also to see that we cannot be satisfied with baptismal unity alone.

But, someone may say, this interpretation of Anglican identity makes Anglicans no different from other baptized Christians. Precisely! Our fundamental Christian identity must be one that we share with our fellow baptized,

communicant Christians throughout the world and in the history of the Church. It would indeed be retrograde if, as Anglicans becoming more conscious of our historical distinctiveness and of the resources of our heritage, we were to attempt to define ourselves in a way that distanced us from Christians of other communions. It is solely on the basis of our solidarity with all Christ's people in his universal body that we can be free to pursue our distinctive Anglican way. Our fundamental identity is that given in Christ; confessional identities are secondary and require continual conversion to Christ and the gospel.<sup>13</sup>

That does not mean that there is nothing that is distinctive of Anglicanism as an expression of the Church. There are a number of features that contribute to Anglican identity within the family of Christian traditions. A central feature is its approach to questions of authority. There is the threefold appeal to Scripture, reason and tradition (to give them in Richard Hooker's order of precedence), but without a strong central magisterium to adjudicate on pressing issues when these three do not all point in one direction. There is the combination of episcopal pastoral leadership and oversight with conciliar, synodical church government in which laity and clergy are not merely consulted but have constitutional roles. There is the concentration on essentials, on central abiding truths, on fundamentals, that co-exists with much latitude in their interpretation. There is the tolerance and comprehensiveness of a range of internal traditions – catholic, evangelical and central – each touched by a spectrum of stances from conservative to radical. There is the weight that is placed on the corporate celebration of the liturgy and the lightness of touch with which juridical sanctions are invoked.

In addition to this constellation of features pertaining to authority in the Church, there are other elements of Anglican distinctiveness that should not be overlooked: a warm endorsement of the principle of inculturation of liturgy, theology and pastoral practice, as local customs, traditions and cultural expressions are used as a vehicle for the gospel as far as possible; the comprehending participation of the laity in worship, government and the discernment of doctrine; the tradition of vernacular liturgy and Bible reading; the combination of catholic order (the threefold ministry) with the Reformed affirmation of clerical marriage; the consequent role model of the clergy household within the community; and last but by no means least, the parochial approach to ministry that casts its mission in the mould of pastoral care, is not troubled by fuzzy edges, and seeks the integration of the committed Christian community with the wider local community through service.

I now want to assess the three models for any lasting significance that they may have, under the heading of 'Critical conservation'.

### **Critical conservation**

Having affirmed the communion model of Anglican ecclesial identity, let us now ask whether there is anything of lasting value that deserves to be conserved from the nation-as-church model of Anglican identity, given that it must seem of merely academic interest to the greater part of the Anglican Communion. I suggest three items:

The Church's mission is to all. Anglicanism can never be a sect. The Church of England is a territorial church and embraces all within its parishes who do not refuse its ministry. Its ethos is essentially inclusive, not exclusive. Most other Churches of the Anglican Communion, even where they are not territorially based, are guided by the same principle of inclusivity, being outward-looking and offering their pastoral ministry to all who are willing to receive it. Communion ecclesiology understands the meaning of community.

On the basis of their baptism, lay people have a vital role in church government. The Reformed English Church carried forward the central principles of the pre-Reformation conciliar movement: constitutionalism, representation and consent. In the historical nation-as-church model of Anglicanism, lay people were given rights that they did not enjoy in the medieval Church. They received the cup as well as the bread at Holy Communion; the Bible was available to them; services were in the vernacular. In Parliament, their representatives (though representation was very imperfectly conceived until the succession of reform acts in the nineteenth and early twentieth centuries) had a voice in the doctrine and worship of the Church. The Reformation has been called the triumph of the laity. Today lay people are even more strongly represented in the councils of the Church, at parish, deanery, diocesan and national level. (In the Roman Catholic Church, while lay people assist in leading worship and may be consulted by the

bishop or the parish priest, they have no constitutional place in church governance.)

A branch of the Church has the authority to reform itself. This principle, which underpinned and legitimated the Reformation, remains crucial today. Anglican Churches have, over the past century, reformed their structures of government by establishing a synodical system, revised the rules for the conduct of the Church's life (canon law), rewritten their liturgies, and are now in the process of reforming their ministry by removing the barriers to the admission of women to the threefold order. Without giving blanket endorsement to all these changes, which need to be considered on their merits, we can see them as examples of particular churches attempting to reform and renew their life. It is salutary to recall that the Roman Catholic Church denied that the Church of England and other Churches had any authority to reform themselves in the sixteenth century and denies their right to reform themselves now.

Is there anything of value that deserves to be conserved from the second paradigm of Anglican identity, the apostolic succession model? We recall that such proponents of this model as Newman and Manning gave it up in despair, that it has never received explicit endorsement in any Anglican formularies, and that, ironically, it is not countenanced by the Roman Catholic Church. Nevertheless, there is much that ought to be rescued from it that belongs to a sound ecclesiology.

The bishop is the effective symbol of unity. There is an emerging ecumenical consensus that any united Church of the future will have bishops in the historical succession and that they will be regarded as symbols of unity. I have used the phrase 'effective symbols': bishops must above all relate to the communion (koinonia) experienced by a church through the sacraments, the mutual unconditional acceptance, founded on our common baptism into the body of Christ, our common adherence to the baptismal faith, and the fulfilment and strengthening of this in the Eucharist, the sacrament of unity. Episcopacy can be justified not only as an institution that goes back to the beginnings of the

Church, but because the communion that is the life of the Church, and that transcends locality and particularity, requires bishops as its symbolic focus. Bishops are pre-eminently ‘persons in relation’. However, if a bishop puts his or her unity function above all others (above teaching the faith, above defending truth, above efficient oversight and effective discipline, above leadership pointing to the future) then even unity itself will elude him or her.

Bishops are entitled to canonical obedience from clergy and lay office-holders ‘in all things lawful and honest’. We have already noted the common observation of historians that the catholic revival in the Church of England, which purported to exalt bishops, in practice undermined their authority. On grounds of conscience, Anglo-Catholic clergy often refused canonical obedience to their bishop, particularly over ceremonial matters.

We should remain in communion with our bishop. It goes without saying that we should do all in our power to remain in communion with all those of our fellow Christians who are willing to be in communion with us. It is an extremely grave matter, spiritually, to break communion, except over the most serious doctrinal or moral issue, one that must touch the integrity of the gospel itself and undermine our salvation. If the bishop is the effective symbol of unity and communion, we have a special obligation to remain in communion with him or her. We do not have to agree with everything that our bishop says or does, but we are under an obligation to remain in communion. Breaking communion is not an appropriate way of expressing our hurt and dismay. Theologically, severance of communion can only be justified when the issue concerns the basis of our communion in God’s act of salvation in Jesus Christ, our baptismal incorporation into the body of Christ and the trinitarian baptismal faith itself.<sup>14</sup>

#### **Questions for reflection and discussion**

What relevance, if any, do the three models of Anglican self-definition have for the mission of the Church today?

What is distinctive about Anglicanism as you have experienced it, compared with other Christian traditions that you are familiar with?

**For further reading**

Avis, Paul, *Anglicanism and the Christian Church: Theological Resources in Historical Perspective*, London and New York: T&T Clark, 2002.

Bartlett, Alan, *A Passionate Balance: The Anglican Tradition*, London: Darton, Longman & Todd, 2007.

Sachs, W. L., *The Transformation of Anglicanism: From State Church to Global Communion*, Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1993.

Sykes, Stephen, *Unashamed Anglicanism*, London: Darton, Longman & Todd, 1995.

### The threefold appeal of Anglican ecclesiology

In interpreting its own nature, Anglicanism has consistently made a threefold appeal. It has pointed to three sources that together constitute its ecclesial identity. Anglicans have appealed, first, to the catholic tradition, to historical continuity in the life, worship and ministry of the Church, and to the authority of the undivided Church of the early centuries; second, to the principles of the Reformation, grounded in a return to Scripture and a recovery of the liberating gospel of free forgiveness for Christ's sake (justification by grace alone through faith) and the consequences of this for the reform of the Church in the light of the gospel, especially the right and duty of a particular branch of the Christian Church to reform itself in the light of Scripture; and, third, to the results of scholarly enquiry ('sound learning') applied to Scripture and tradition, freely pursued and openly debated. Let us examine each of these more closely.

#### **Looking to the Church in history: the appeal to catholic tradition**

Anglicanism has never wavered in its conviction that it belongs to the catholic Church. This belonging has been put in various ways, the terms 'part', 'portion' or 'branch' being especially favoured. The catholicity of Anglicanism is essential to its self-understanding. This claim has been supported in three main ways.

The catholicity of Anglicanism has been justified historically by pointing to the antiquity of the British Church from which other provinces of the worldwide Anglican Communion have ultimately stemmed. The British Church had its representatives at a council of the catholic Church as early as 314 at Arles, and the Celtic Church flourished long before the arrival of Augustine of Canterbury in 597. Anglicans emphatically do not believe that their Church originated at the

## Reformation.

The catholicity of Anglicanism has been justified theologically, for Anglicanism incorporates and upholds the ancient structures of the catholic Church: the canon of Scripture, the historic creeds, the dominical sacraments of holy baptism and the holy Eucharist (set in the framework of liturgies that hark back to primitive forms), and the historic episcopate. The basis on which all of these are accepted is the authority of the early undivided Church to interpret and clarify what remained unclear and incomplete in Scripture itself as far as the life of the Church is concerned (and emphatically not as regards the way of salvation). These structures of catholicity are enshrined in the Chicago-Lambeth Quadrilateral that has been repeatedly affirmed since 1888 by Lambeth Conferences and the governing body of The Episcopal Church of the USA in particular.

The catholicity of Anglicanism can be supported polemically by referring back to the abortive reforming councils of the pre-Reformation period. Anglican ecclesiology makes contact with conciliar rather than monarchical catholicism. It accepts the authority of General Councils but denies that acceptance of the primacy and authority of the pope is essential to catholicity. The Anglican critique of certain features of Roman Catholicism has been informed, explicitly or tacitly, by the conciliar model of catholicism. Anglican polemicists have consistently pointed to Rome's inveterate tendency towards authoritarianism, with its attendant repression of theological liberty, its reluctance to accept new insights and its fixation on juridical modes of oversight. They have pointed out that the papal regime has proved historically incompatible with a fully conciliar view of catholicism – from the triumph of the fifteenth-century popes over the putative reforming councils, to the imposition of conservative bishops against local wishes by the Vatican today. The synodical structure of the Anglican Churches, on the other hand, with the vital role in oversight assigned to lay people, embodies this distinctive, conciliar understanding of catholicism.<sup>1</sup>

It is, however, paradoxical that Anglicanism cannot now affirm its catholicity by identifying itself with any other extant tradition that also preserves intact the ancient structures of catholicism, particularly the historic episcopate. Anglican holy orders, celebrations of the Eucharist and authority within its own borders are not recognized by the Roman Catholic Church. And for its own part, Anglicanism does not acknowledge the immediate universal jurisdiction of the pope, nor papal infallibility, nor the particular Marian dogmas that form the

content of such infallible pronouncements as there have been. That does not mean that as Anglicans we can leave Rome out of the reckoning. The work of ARCIC (especially the Final Report of 1982 and The Gift of Authority of 1999) and, for example, the response by the House of Bishops of the Church of England to the papal encyclical *Ut Unum Sint*, show a readiness to consider the principle of a reformed universal primacy.<sup>2</sup>

George Guiver CR has argued that Anglicanism is weakened, even emasculated, by its separation from the deep-rooted Latin tradition of the Western Church:

Here is a cruse of wisdom and folly on the grandest of scales, and with a guts and readiness to acknowledge the dark physicality and bile of human nature, and the outrageous grandeur of our destiny, that cannot easily be found among polite Anglo-Saxons when left to themselves. Anglicanism's great merits bring with them the fault of an incapacity for the large-scale and audacious, and no great inclination to strive beyond homely horizons. Its gifts of comprehensiveness and understatement are never likely to set the world alight unless they rediscover the deep mulch and vigour of the tradition of the Western Church, whose whole history is part of our psyche, a doorway to our very selves, if we would acknowledge it.<sup>3</sup>

Charles Gore, the great Anglo-Catholic bishop and theologian (d. 1932), argued that what we seek in Anglicanism is not Romanism without the pope, but catholicism without Rome.<sup>4</sup> Guiver does not believe that they are separable. It would seem that a good deal more exploration is needed here than even ARCIC has been able to achieve so far.

The differences between Anglicans and Orthodox are equally intractable, though they do not include disagreement about jurisdiction or dogmas – thankfully, the Orthodox do not think in terms of either jurisdiction or dogmas. Although international Anglican–Orthodox theological dialogue has shown remarkable convergences, Anglicanism has not yet received unequivocal acceptance from the Orthodox by their own criteria.<sup>5</sup>

Like Rome and the Orthodox, together with the Reformation Churches who would emphatically defend their own catholicity, Anglicanism stands by its

claim to belong to the catholic Church, but it does this without unchurching other claimants. However, since it cannot at present become identified with either of the two main catholic, episcopal, pre-Reformation traditions, we are bound, I think, to conclude that the appeal to catholicism is necessary but not sufficient to define Anglican ecclesial identity.

### **Looking to the Bible: the appeal to the Reformation**

Anglicanism is a reformed faith. Though the English Church long pre-dated the Reformation, it was decisively marked by the events of the sixteenth century. They gave it its biblical centre of gravity, its lay character, its earthing in family and home, its intimate relationship with the English language. The very *raison d'être* of Anglicanism rests on an appeal to Reformation principles, for if Anglicans did not believe, with all the Reformers, that a branch of the Church has the inherent authority to reform itself, the events of the sixteenth century and the continued separate existence of the Anglican Communion could not be justified.

It has become customary for Anglicans to be rather apologetic about the Reformation. They cannot help feeling rather sheepish about the political manipulation, the dubious motives of Henry VIII, the wholesale dissolution of the monasteries, the compliance of Archbishop Thomas Cranmer, the iconoclasm, the inadequate theology of the 1552 Prayer Book, followed by the astute compromises of the Elizabethan settlement. The apparent lack of principle is disturbing. Of course there is much to be ashamed of in what took place then. It must have seemed to many of the faithful that Christianity itself was being obliterated. But we need equally to remember that there is much to embarrass Christians of other traditions in their particular histories. It must be even more difficult for a devout Roman Catholic to come to terms with the corruption, ruthlessness and immorality of the pre-Reformation papacy because of the exalted claims that concurrently were being made for 'the vicar of Christ'.

The prevalent excessive uneasiness among Anglicans about the Reformation can be shown to derive from one particular strand of the Oxford Movement – the strand that diverged from the mainstream consensus of Anglican ecclesiology

until then, namely, that the Church of England was a reformed Church that took its stand on Reformation principles. These principles included, crucially, the paramount authority of Scripture and the right and duty of a particular – that is to say, national – church to reform its life and worship in the light of Scripture and the primitive Church, notwithstanding the veto of the Bishop of Rome. The irony of that departure from consensus is that it was founded on no great acquaintance with the thought and writings of the Reformers, but was instead profoundly influenced by unhistorical assumptions and crude comparisons between the sixteenth century and the nineteenth.<sup>6</sup>

In essence, the more radical of the Tractarians (Hurrell Froude, John Henry Newman and to a lesser extent John Keble and Edward Bouverie Pusey) overlooked the aspiration of the Reformers to attain a true catholicity grounded in faithfulness to Scripture and Christian antiquity. They discounted – if they ever knew – the disclaimers of the Reformers to be setting up a new Church, and their professed purpose to restore the face of the catholic Church so that it might once again reflect the purity and integrity of the Church of Scripture and antiquity. Since, however, Rome also claimed the authority of Scripture and antiquity, it is important to remind ourselves that the Reformers set the authority of Scripture and antiquity over and above the contemporary empirical Church with its accumulated traditions.

Thanks to modern biblical and historical scholarship, we are far more conscious today than the Reformers were of the intimate interconnection between Scripture and tradition, and are able to see Scripture as set within the context of tradition, or as the authoritative element in tradition, as well as the paramount criterion for interpreting tradition. It becomes necessary then for us to transpose Reformation polemic into more contemporary terms and to talk about the authority of normative tradition over normed tradition, or of primary tradition over secondary tradition. But it is salutary to recognize that this way of looking at the matter was not entirely alien to the Reformers. It would appear to be implicit in their twofold appeal to Scripture and the early Church (‘antiquity’), which they believed to be in harmony.

On this basis of Scripture and primitive tradition, the Reformers rejected certain central aspects of medieval Christianity, particularly the claims of the papacy: claims to exercise universal jurisdiction, both spiritual and temporal; to enunciate doctrine without appeal; to possess the sole right to call a General Council and to preside over it; to give dispensations from biblical injunctions.

The Reformers also rejected any sacerdotal, mediatorial understanding of the ordained ministry, particularly as that was expressed in compulsory sacramental confession, the propitiatory sacrifice of the Mass and the quantitative conception of merit that could be accumulated and transferred. All these practices, they believed, could not be justified from Scripture, which contained all things necessary to salvation (Article 6 of the Thirty-Nine Articles of Religion: see below).

On the same grounds, the Reformers promoted a number of positive reforms: that the Bible should be available in the vernacular; that the liturgy should also be in a language ‘understood of the people’ and that they should participate in it; that the laity should receive communion in both kinds (the cup as well as the bread) and that communion should be more frequent; that the laity should have a role in the government of the Church and that the clergy should be free to marry. Underlying both negative and positive aspects of the Reformers’ programme was the fundamental Reformation doctrine of justification through grace by faith and its corollary, the universal priesthood of the faithful. The logic of salvation full and free governed the specific practical reforms.

However, the Reformers refrained from taking reforming principles to their logical conclusion. For example, they did not claim that everything done in the Church must be justified by explicit reference to Scripture. Neither Luther nor Calvin, and certainly not the English Reformers, insisted on a biblical blueprint for detailed patterns of worship or structures of ministry. They did not condemn bishops as such, and Luther and others even left the door open (or at least slightly ajar!) for a reformed papacy that would preach the gospel and correct abuses in the Church. The Reformers gave considerable discretion to the Church to take responsibility for its own life, government and worship. Luther regarded forms of ecclesiastical government pragmatically. Only the ministry of word and sacrament was absolutely essential. Oversight could be handled by the Christian magistrate (ruler) in an emergency situation. Calvin did not assert the form of church government by elders (presbyterianism) as by divine right; that position arrived with his successor Theodore Beza. The English Reformers right up to Whitgift and Hooker, at the end of the sixteenth century, deliberately refrained from claiming divine right for episcopacy.

There was a consensus, though of varying degrees, that holy Scripture had a God-given but restricted purpose: not to provide precept and precedent for the secondary questions concerned with the outward order of the Church, but to

show the way of salvation. The Reformers made a space for ‘things indifferent’ (adiaphora). These were things that did not make a difference to one’s salvation. In the case of Luther, Melanchthon and the English Reformers it was a very considerable space. In the case of Calvin and Zwingli, it was somewhat restricted. Richard Hooker was not comfortable about describing any aspect of the life of the Church as though it did not matter. Rather than ‘things indifferent’, Hooker preferred the phrase ‘things accessory’, that is, accessory to the gospel. In other words, the Reformers looked not simply to the Bible but also to the Church and to human rational discernment. They took the Church of antiquity as a model of biblical interpretation and credited the contemporary Church with the Christian freedom to take responsibility for its affairs – provided always that the binding injunctions of Scripture were not infringed and that man-made rules were not imposed on Christian consciences before the presence of God (coram Deo: Luther’s catchphrase). The reform was a corrective; it did not replace the Church of the ages. We are bound then, I believe, to conclude that the appeal to the Reformation is necessary but not sufficient to define Anglican ecclesial identity.

### **Looking to reason: the appeal to scholarly enquiry**

Anglicanism sets out to offer a rational faith. It believes that its position in Christendom as a Church that is both catholic and reformed can be justified by an appeal to sound learning. Its catholicism is not enslaved to tradition nor is its reformed character in bondage to biblical literalism. It is notably receptive to new insights deriving from ‘secular’ disciplines – receptive, not in the sense that it is prone to embrace these insights immediately, uncritically or without resistance, but in the sense that it gives scope and freedom to its clergy, as well as to its laity, to pursue such insights and to promote them without undue fear of ecclesiastical discipline or censure. In due course (though it never seems soon enough) it adapts its beliefs and practices to those insights (as we are seeing today with regard to the Christian feminist critique of sexism, androcentrism and patriarchalism in the Bible and the tradition).

Such a vindication of Anglicanism’s appeal to rationality could quote the celebrated dictum of Mandell Creighton (Bishop of London at the turn of the

nineteenth century) that the formula that best explains the position of the Anglican Church is that it rests on an appeal to sound learning. Neville Figgis CR (the Anglican political philosopher who died in 1919) – not by accident an admirer of Creighton – also could be called upon to second this opinion. However, several caveats should be entered immediately.

All Christian Churches have their own illustrious traditions of learning. Sound learning is not unique to Anglicanism, nor is Anglican sound learning necessarily more impressive than that of other traditions. I hardly need to illustrate the scholarship of the Roman Catholic Church. But as far as the Reformation Churches are concerned, the Protestant Reformers were humanist scholars steeped in the methods and conclusions of the Renaissance rediscovery of classical and Christian antiquity, and the Lutheran and Reformed Churches have enjoyed a theological distinction that is second to none. Although the scholarship of the seventeenth-century Anglican clergy was said to be the admiration of the world (*clerus Britannicus stupor mundi*), that distinction can hardly be claimed to have survived to the present day, though there are outstanding individual exceptions. The Anglican Communion is not paramount among Christian traditions for its scholarship, and Anglicanism is still notoriously weak in the area of doctrinal or systematic theology.

Anglicans cannot claim that the events of the sixteenth century and subsequent developments were a direct translation of the findings of scholarship into action. As Hensley Henson (Bishop of Durham before the Second World War) memorably said, it was not sound learning that filled the land with ruined monasteries and brought about bloodshed in abundance. However, Henson may have overstated his objection to Creighton's claim. The dissolution of the monasteries was not unconnected with the findings of scholars that the religious vocation could not be supported from Scripture and the very earliest period of the Church's history. And sixteenth-century polemicists never wearied of pointing out the contrast between the wealth and luxury of some religious foundations and the poverty and simplicity of the apostles. So while it is not necessary to claim a direct translation of sound learning into every aspect of church policy in order to assert a privileged place for scholarship in the Anglican scheme, it must be acknowledged that the record of the Church of England, to look no further, is not particularly illustrious in this respect: resistance to biblical

criticism and evolutionary theory are notable examples from the nineteenth century.

It is not enough to show that Anglicans have often been extremely learned. A more pertinent question would be, What have they done with their learning? How have they deployed it? In answering that question, one would have to acknowledge that Anglican scholarship has frequently been employed polemically and tendentiously. It has been used to justify the unjustifiable, as when Hooker makes non-preaching clergy look like God's gift to the Church of England and non-residence in their benefice appear like a beneficial pastoral strategy.<sup>7</sup> Learning has also been prostituted to make godly men caught up in the quandaries and compromises of their time look like cynical political time-servers, for example, in the radical Tractarian Hurrell Froude's reading of the Reformation.

It is sometimes said that scholarship, with all its human failings, if allowed to be freely pursued, will correct its own shortcomings and excesses. The expression 'freely pursued' is the key to understanding the Anglican appeal to sound learning. It is not, as we have said, learning as such that is distinctive of Anglicanism, but the liberty that Anglicanism gives to scholars and theologians (even when they are priests or bishops) to research, to develop, to publish and to defend their ideas – and then to have them criticized and perhaps demolished by other scholars in turn. When Anglicanism appeals to sound learning, it assumes the freedom to pursue that learning. When it appeals to reason, it is the role of reason in rational discussion that it intends. And this openness and toleration applies not merely to laity, as it would in some other traditions, but precisely to the clergy, the Church's 'official representatives', so to speak. Thus the distinctive Anglican comprehensiveness or breadth of opinion and practice is entailed in the appeal to sound learning. Comprehensiveness in turn rests on the distinctive Anglican approach to authority and is an expression of it. Anglican authority is dispersed and corporate, though it presupposes a framework or foundation of central Christian beliefs and practices. Doctrinal and ethical decisions are not laid down by a central magisterium but are explored by the whole Church over a period of time until a consensus emerges and a position is reached that carries widespread conviction.

Thus the appeal to learning and reason in the context of mutual toleration itself depends on the framework provided by Anglican catholicity. It presupposes the hallowed structures of catholicism that Anglicanism has retained from the undivided Church (particularly the canon, the creeds, the liturgy and the oversight of bishops), which exert a restraining influence on unfettered speculation about the central Christian mysteries. Anglican clerical scholars, however radical they may appear in their explorations, are still required to celebrate the liturgy, say the creeds and give canonical obedience to their bishops. Although Anglicanism's juridical constraints are weak, its moral and pastoral constraints are correspondingly strong.

Furthermore, the appeal to liberty of learning and to reason itself depends on the prior appeal to the Reformation with its principle of justification by faith, which in turn gives rise to the doctrines of the universal priesthood and 'the freedom of a Christian man (woman)'. Christians are baptized into Christ's messianic body and therefore participate in his prophetic, as well as his priestly and kingly, offices. They are thereby mandated to proclaim the mighty acts of God and to pursue the truth as it is in Jesus. Some 'liberty of prophesying' (in Bishop Jeremy Taylor's seventeenth-century phrase) is intrinsic to the Christian's baptismal status. When we see in this way that the appeal to sound learning and to rationality is itself dependent on the catholicity and the reformed character of Anglicanism, we are bound to conclude, I believe, that the appeal to scholarly enquiry is necessary but not sufficient to define Anglican ecclesial identity. Anglican ecclesiology makes not a single or double but a triple appeal. Catholicity, Reformation principles and scholarship freely pursued are mutually supportive and mutually interpretative.

### **Towards an Anglican synthesis**

Our analysis of the sources of Anglican identity has shown that, while appeal has consistently been made to the catholic tradition, to the principles of the Reformation and to sound learning and open debate, no one of these sources is sufficient by itself to define Anglican identity. However, taken together, in some kind of synthesis, they seem to offer a noble vision of a reasonable, reformed catholicism. But what sort of synthesis might this be? What kind of combination

unites the catholic, reformed and scholarly components of the Anglican ideal? Several versions of the Anglican synthesis have been advanced.

#### **An historical accident?**

This interpretation of the Anglican synthesis, as an accident of history, stresses the element of sheer historical contingency in Anglicanism, seeing it as merely a pragmatic adjustment to the changes and chances of the historical process. Hensley Henson claimed that the reformed English Church was the product of 'the cold sagacity of Tudor statecraft'. It cannot be denied that Elizabeth I's policy of comprehension was a balancing act intended to include all groups within the nation except those actually sworn to overthrow her regime – radical, 'separatist' Protestants and subversive Roman Catholics (by no means all). When she declined 'to make windows into men's hearts and minds', provided that they observed outward conformity, Elizabeth was not embracing any noble ideal of religious toleration, but exhibiting an astute sense of what strains the Church and nation could stand.

The element of contingency, of historical accident, is certainly present in the Anglican synthesis. But is there any Christian tradition that is without it? All communions of the Christian Church are, to a considerable degree, what they are now as a result of political factors, injected by emperors, kings, popes and prelates, and pragmatic adjustments to those factors – as well as being shaped by more diffuse economic and social movements. That is not to deny that such bodies are, at the same time, the body of Christ, brought into being by the grace of word and sacrament through the work of the Holy Spirit. If Anglicanism is to any extent the outcome of historical accident, so are all the major Christian traditions. Nevertheless, the question remains: can a synthesis based purely on historical contingency have integrity?

#### **A cynical compromise?**

If the first interpretation of the Anglican synthesis, the threefold appeal, stresses historical contingency, the second interpretation emphasizes the element of design. It claims that Anglicanism intentionally embraced a principle of calculated moderation. It sees the Anglican synthesis as a halfway house, a golden mean, a safe middle path through all extremes. Anglican apologetic in the seventeenth century celebrated the middle way (*via media*) between (as the poet-priest George Herbert put it) the allurements of Rome ('the painted harlot on the hill') and the uncomeliness of the Protestant Churches ('the slovenly wench in the valley'); between (as Bishop Simon Patrick put it) 'the meretricious gaudiness of the Church of Rome and the squalid sluttishness of fanatic conventicles'; between (as the scholar and politician George Savile put it) 'the lethargic ignorance of popish dreams' and the 'frenzy of fanatic visions'. The language of these earlier divines seems offensive in this polite ecumenical age and reveals how far we have come from the ecclesiastical trench warfare of the seventeenth century. The historian Thomas Babington Macaulay gave this interpretation his imprimatur when he pointed out the compromise involved in a Church that had, as he saw it – not entirely accurately – Protestant Articles of Religion but a 'popish' liturgy; that retained bishops but without making them of the essence (*esse*) of the Church; that rejected transubstantiation but 'required her children to receive the memorials of divine love meekly kneeling upon their knees'; that, while abrogating compulsory sacramental confession, 'gently invited the dying penitent to confess his sins'. Archbishop William Temple, the great Anglican synthesizer of the twentieth century, saw Anglicanism as splitting the difference between bare Protestantism and (pre-Vatican II) Roman Catholicism.

It is not difficult to criticize this model. What becomes of the middle way, construed like this as the avoidance of extremes, when the 'extremes' move towards the middle – when, for example, the Roman Catholic Church reforms itself, as at the Second Vatican Council, throwing off such quantities of 'meretricious gaudiness' and 'lethargic ignorance' as might offend a rather Protestant Anglican conscience; or when Protestant Churches themselves come to be perceived as standing more for sobriety and sincerity than for 'slovenliness' or 'fanaticism'? Macaulay was no theologian and his analysis is flawed. He underestimated the catholicity of the Thirty-Nine Articles, especially the first ten, and misconstrued the continuity between the Book of Common Prayer and its medieval liturgical precursors. William Temple rather discredited his own version of the *via media* by actually admitting that Anglicanism tended to 'sit on the fence'.

The model of the Anglican synthesis as a contrived compromise does certainly attempt to do justice to the moderation and balance that has sometimes been characteristic of Anglican theological method – what John Henry Newman called its ‘calmness and caution’ and Paul Elmer More described as its ‘love of balance, restraint, moderation, measure’. But these virtues are capable of a more suspicious interpretation. They are the very qualities that permit unreformed practices and the abuse of power and privilege to flourish. They hardly generate the spiritual dynamism that causes the gates of hell to quake! This approach points less to the theological discrimination that picks its way through the pitfalls of heresy and schism, and more to the fearful mediocrity that is motivated by timidity, complacency and indolence. Can this ever have integrity?

### **Binding together?**

A true synthesis, one that has theological integrity, cannot be attained by trusting to the accidents of history or by resorting to cynical compromise. Only some kind of creative tension or dialectical interaction can generate genuine synthesis out of the threefold appeal that Anglicanism makes. In the mid-nineteenth century, F. D. Maurice rejected the compromise formula of Anglican ecclesial identity. The Reformation, Maurice insisted, was not a cowardly or cunning compromise between incompatible extremes. The catholic (traditional) and reformed (biblical) elements reacted upon each other, producing a ‘healthy effervescence’. As yet, he claimed, no neutral salt had resulted from the combination! Maurice was seeking a critical and creative comprehension in which the positive truths to which each tradition witnessed (but which became distorted in isolated systems) would be acknowledged and given free reign.

Maurice’s insights were developed a century later by Michael Ramsey, to whom I owe the phrase ‘binding together’. In the Anglican vocation, according to Ramsey, the paramount authority of the gospel (the Reformation’s contribution), the given reality of the Church catholic (which comes down to us through living tradition) and sound learning (or interaction with the modern world and its discoveries) are ‘bound together’. It is when they are torn asunder and elaborated systematically in isolation that you have the distorted ideological systems: biblical literalism (fundamentalism); blinkered traditionalism infused with

uncritical nostalgia; and arrogant rationalism that subjects the mystery of Christian revelation to its own narrow analytical criteria. But when bound together and held together in a community life of prayer, study and sacrifice, the three vital ingredients of the Anglican appeal interact – stimulating, criticizing and modifying each other in a real and living synthesis.<sup>8</sup>

In conclusion, perhaps we can take our cue from the realm of psychotherapy. In the Jungian approach particularly, mental and spiritual wholeness comes from recognizing, accepting and reconciling the tensions that emerge from deep in the psyche, predominantly from the unconscious. So it is with ‘the mind of the Church’. The first step is to acknowledge and confront the tensions, and that can only be done when there is toleration and spiritual liberty. The second step is to accept the fact of these tensions and to engage with them and in so doing to release life-giving energy for the Church’s theological exploration and pastoral mission. As tensions are examined, misunderstandings can be resolved, stereotypes can be overcome, common ground can be discovered and some degree of genuine reconciliation can be attained.

This suggests the important truth that it is precisely people that must be bound together before ever principles can be. That binding together is given already in our common baptism. It is articulated at the Peace in the Eucharist, using the words of Scripture: ‘We are the body of Christ. In the one Spirit we were all baptized into one body. Let us then pursue all that makes for peace and builds up our common life.’ The binding together is realized and strengthened in Holy Communion. Thus baptism and the Eucharist provide the primary ecclesiological condition for the mutual acceptance of one another as fellow Christians, united with one another through our union with Christ (cf. Romans 15.7). That mutual reception forms the basis for a synthesis that is not merely a meeting of minds, but a true communion (koinonia) in the Spirit.

#### **Questions for reflection and discussion**

How has the authority of Scripture been affected by modern critical study?

Can we ever stand outside our tradition?

What part does reason play in our interpretation of the Bible and tradition?

**For further reading**

Avis, Paul, *In Search of Authority: Anglican Theological Method from the Reformation to the Enlightenment*, London and New York: T&T Clark, 2014.

McAdoo, H. R., *The Spirit of Anglicanism: A Survey of Anglican Theological Method in the Seventeenth Century*, London: A. & C. Black, 1965.

Platten, Stephen (ed.), *Anglicanism and the Western Christian Tradition*, Norwich: Canterbury Press, 2003.

## The sources of Anglican ecclesiology

### **The Bible**

Anglicanism draws on a number of sources, both ancient and modern, in working out its understanding of the Church. Primarily, of course, it acknowledges its dependence on holy Scripture as containing all things necessary to be believed or performed in order to attain salvation (Article 6 of the Thirty-Nine Articles). For most of Anglican history, the scriptural requirements for salvation would have been regarded as including baptism and probably Holy Communion. Even the creeds are held to derive their authority from scriptural warrant for their doctrine (Article 8).

The Bible is read extensively and comprehensively in Anglican services ('the lessons') and lay Anglicans have long been encouraged to study the Bible themselves. A fundamental principle of the Reformation was that the Bible should be available to all in their own language. Anglicanism shares the Reformation's implicit faith in Scripture as able to instruct the ignorant, reform the wayward and convey clearly the way of salvation through Christ.

This way of understanding the authority of Scripture entails that the Bible is not upheld as a source-book of binding rules and precedents for every aspect of the Church's life. The English Reformers regarded the outward ordering and government (polity) of the Church as of secondary importance and believed that a degree of freedom was given to the Church, under the magistrate (the civil ruler), to enact what seemed fitting, both in its worship and government. Richard Hooker reinforced this principle of freedom by grounding it in the divine reason by means of which God providentially orders the universe through natural law. But Hooker believed that to abandon episcopacy would be to depart from the apostolic pattern of the Church. This commitment to the ancient threefold

ministry of the Church became, by the seventeenth century, a non-negotiable platform of Anglicanism. Thus, in Anglicanism, Scripture shows the way of salvation but reason and tradition play their part in shaping the life of the Church.

## **Tradition**

Tradition is a notoriously ambiguous term. It may have a narrower or broader meaning. Ecumenical theology has helped to clarify the range of meanings. In the narrow sense tradition (sometimes spelt with a capital T) stands for the central truths of Christianity, the faith once delivered to the saints, the gospel. In the broader sense, tradition embraces the entire ongoing life of the Church in all its diversity, like a great stream carrying the life of the Church down through the centuries. In Anglicanism, tradition is usually understood in the first sense, as early or normative tradition (the tradition of the catholic Church, going back beyond the Reformation to the legacy of the undivided and 'primitive' (that is, original, uncorrupted) Church).

Anglicanism derives its insistence on the two dominical sacraments (that is, the sacraments of baptism and the Eucharist, instituted by the Lord) from Scripture itself. But it draws its use of the creeds, the canon of Scripture and the historic episcopate from the tradition of the early Church. Anglicanism obviously recognizes the validity of the tradition of the undivided Church in supplementing and interpreting what is revealed in Scripture – not about the essential truths of faith or about the way of salvation, which are held to be clearly revealed in the Bible, but about the common life, belief and order of the Church. The catholicity of Anglicanism rests on a recognition that the Church is not only a mystical body (let alone an invisible entity), known only to God, nor merely a local gathering of people for worship, but a visible society that is both divine and human, spanning the globe and enduring through history. The structures of the Church are not derived solely from Scripture (few, in any tradition, would claim that they were).

However, as we have already noted, the authority of tradition in Anglicanism is subordinated to that of Scripture. Thus Canon A5 of the Church of England

states that the doctrine of that Church 'is grounded in the Holy Scriptures, and in such teachings of the ancient Fathers and Councils of the Church as are agreeable to the said Scriptures'.

## **The historic formularies**

The Preface to the Declaration of Assent (Canon C15) of the Church of England states that the historic formularies bear witness to Christian truth. But what are the historic formularies? The Preface mentions the Thirty-Nine Articles of Religion, the Book of Common Prayer and the Ordering of Bishops, Priests and Deacons. The current status of these texts varies among the Churches of the Anglican Communion. But let us look briefly at these in turn before asking whether they need to be supplemented by other historic sources.

### **The Thirty-Nine Articles**

The Articles of Religion are derived from a series of doctrinal statements put out by the bishops and the King during the reign of Henry VIII. The Forty-Two Articles appeared in 1553 and these were reduced to thirty-nine ten years later. The Articles in their present form were issued in 1571 under Queen Elizabeth I. A cursory glance at the Articles will show that they are not a complete account of Christian doctrine, even less an Anglican systematic theology. They are a response to matters of controversy in the sixteenth century. They make certain central affirmations directed against several specific targets: anti-trinitarianism, Roman Catholicism and radical Protestantism.

Speculative heterodoxy in the doctrine of God and in Christology is combatted in the first five Articles, which affirm the Trinitarian and Christological doctrines

of the undivided Church. For example: ‘There is but one living and true God ... And in unity of this Godhead there be three Persons, of one substance, power, and eternity; the Father, the Son, and the Holy Ghost’ (from Article 1).

Roman Catholicism, for whom Queen Elizabeth was a heretic, an outlaw and an impostor, is tackled in Articles 6, 11, 21, 22, 24, 30, 31, 2, 34, 7. For example: ‘The Bishop of Rome hath no jurisdiction in this realm of England’ (from Article 37).

Radical Protestants, who rejected the union of Church and state and advocated gathered communities of more perfect Christians, are attacked in Articles 23, 26, 37, 38. For example: ‘It is lawful for Christian men, at the commandment of the magistrate, to wear weapons, and serve in the wars’ (from Article 37).

Finally, a more extreme form of Calvinism than was acceptable in the Church of England is referred to in Article 17 on predestination and election. The approach here discourages speculation and encourages humble trust and practical obedience: ‘... we must receive God’s promises in such wise, as they be generally set forth to us in Holy Scripture: and, in our doings, that Will of God is to be followed, which we have expressly declared unto us in the Word of God.’

### **The Book of Common Prayer**

The Book of Common Prayer (BCP) in its classical form dates from 1662, when Anglican liturgical worship was reimposed by the Act of Uniformity following the Commonwealth under Oliver Cromwell, during which Anglican practices were banned. Earlier Prayer Books, drawing on patristic, medieval and Reformation sources, had been compiled by Archbishop Thomas Cranmer in 1549 and 1552, the latter being the more Protestant of the two. Worship was now in the vernacular, rather than in Latin, and was the same for the whole country, superseding regional variations.<sup>1</sup> The teaching of the BCP (regarded as distinct from the Thirty-Nine Articles and the Ordinal) is normative for the Church of England and many other churches of the Anglican Communion. The Episcopal Church and other Anglican Churches have their own, later set of liturgies under the title The Book of Common Prayer. However, doctrine is taught only

implicitly in the liturgy.

On the relation between liturgy and doctrine, Louis Weil comments: 'It is not that the liturgy is a didactic tool, but rather that it inevitably articulates an underlying theology.' Weil continues:

The Book of Common Prayer is for Anglicans far more than a collection of rites. Within Anglicanism the Prayer Book is a living expression of the profound union between what we believe and what we pray; [it is] a doctrinal document, not because it may contain such didactic materials as a catechism, or historical materials of doctrinal significance, but because it is in corporate worship that Anglicans find the common ground for their profession of faith.<sup>2</sup>

### **The Ordinal**

Anglican Churches practise ordination by a bishop in the historic succession. Every member Church of the Anglican Communion has its own ordinal or set of ordination services for bishops, priests and deacons, which are regarded as full and equal ministries. These rites are highly instructive for the Anglican understanding of the Church and its ministry. The Church of England has two ordinals: the classic ordinal of Thomas Cranmer, which dates from 1550 and received its definitive form in 1662 (it is appended to the BCP), and the Common Worship Ordinal, which is the one that is invariably used. Since the ministry of clergy and laity is too big a subject to be covered adequately in this little book, I will make some very brief remarks about each of the three orders.<sup>3</sup>

Deacons are in holy orders, unlike Readers or other lay ministers. They have a ministry of word and sacrament, assisting the parish priest liturgically and pastorally. Deacons have a special care for all in need and are called to reach out into the community and to bring the concerns of the community into the liturgical life of the Church. The diaconate is usually regarded as a probationary

year before priesting, but Anglicanism also recognizes a distinctive diaconate to which some are called (The Episcopal Church has a particularly strong distinctive or vocational diaconate). A deacon's calling may be further discerned by the Church and they may go on to be ordained priest. Anglicans have wrestled with the diaconate: it is still evolving.<sup>4</sup>

Presbyters or priests have a ministry of word, sacrament and pastoral oversight (delegated by the bishop). Unlike deacons, presbyters preside at the Eucharist, pronounce absolution to the penitent and give a blessing. They lead and preside at the Eucharist because they lead and preside in the Christian community.<sup>5</sup> In the missionary situation in which the Church finds itself today, priests are called to reinvent their ministry as an apostleship to the unchurched.

Bishops are the chief pastors in the local church or diocese (the expression 'local church' being a theological technical term for the sphere of the bishop's ministry), with oversight of clergy and laity and responsibility for implementing the canon law of the Church where pastoral discipline is required. Bishops are the principal ministers of the sacraments and teachers and guardians of the faith, with the responsibility for providing for the ministry of word, sacrament and pastoral care throughout the diocese. Both individually and as a college, bishops lead the Church and share the governance of the Church in synod with laity and presbyters (sometimes deacons).

### **The canons**

The first of the sources of Anglican ecclesiology that ought to be added to those referred to in that Preface is the canon law of the Church. The canons of a particular Church normally contain certain important ecclesiological statements, and in this connection the canons have suffered undeserved neglect. However, Anglican Churches are not 'confessional' Churches possessing formal and definitive statements of their beliefs in the form of law. Anglican canon law normally points to doctrine stated elsewhere. Remarkable convergence has been discovered between the canons of the various member Churches of the Communion.<sup>6</sup>

The present form of the canon law of the Church of England goes back to the beginning of the seventeenth century, though there was an abortive attempt by Archbishop Cranmer to devise a reformed canon law in the previous century. The twentieth century saw substantial revision of the canons, first under Archbishop Geoffrey Fisher and latterly by the General Synod, which is constantly legislating. The fundamental presupposition of Anglican canon law is the catholicity of the Anglican Churches as part of the catholic Church of Christ (Church of England Canon A1).<sup>7</sup>

### **The Lambeth Quadrilateral**

The Lambeth (or Chicago-Lambeth) Quadrilateral is one of the doctrinal standards of Anglicanism that needs to be added to those that have canonical authority. The Lambeth Conference of 1888 gave its endorsement to a modified version of four Articles agreed by the General Convention of the Protestant Episcopal Church of the USA (now named The Episcopal Church) two years earlier in Chicago. These in turn were adapted from proposals put forward by a presbyter of that Church, William Reed Huntington, in *The Church-Idea: An Essay Towards Unity* in 1870, which has justly been described by J. R. Wright as ‘probably the most significant American Anglican work on ecclesiology’.<sup>8</sup> The Quadrilateral was further elaborated by the 1920 Lambeth Conference in its famous ‘Appeal to All Christian People’ (see below), but without any essential changes.<sup>9</sup>

The four articles of the Quadrilateral are intended to comprise the essentials that Anglicans would insist on in any reunion of the Churches. The Quadrilateral has been frequently reaffirmed by the Lambeth Conference and by member Churches of the Communion since then and is a firmly established authority for Anglican ecclesiology.<sup>10</sup> The four principles are:

‘The Holy Scriptures of the Old and New Testaments, as “containing all things necessary to salvation”, and as being the rule and ultimate standard of faith.’

‘The Apostles’ Creed, as the Baptismal Symbol; and the Nicene Creed, as the sufficient statement of the Christian Faith.’

‘The two Sacraments ordained by Christ himself – Baptism and the Supper of the Lord – ministered with unfailing use of Christ’s Words of Institution, and of the elements ordained by him.’

‘The Historic Episcopate, locally adapted in the methods of its administration to the varying needs of the nations and peoples called of God into the Unity of his Church.’

#### **Other notable statements of the Lambeth Conferences**

The teachings of the Lambeth Conferences supplement the Quadrilateral. Outstanding among them is the ‘Appeal to All Christian People’ issued by the 1920 Lambeth Conference, which significantly described all those who had undergone Trinitarian baptism as members of the Christian Church, and invited the Churches to seek together for unity.

Another seminal statement of the Lambeth Conferences is that on the dispersed nature of Anglican authority produced by a committee of Lambeth 1948 and deservedly regarded as a classical definition of the nature of Anglicanism. It is worth quoting in full:

The positive nature of the authority which binds the Anglican Communion together is ... moral and spiritual, resting on the truth of the Gospel, and on a charity which is patient and willing to defer to the common mind.

Authority, as inherited by the Anglican Communion from the undivided Church of the early centuries of the Christian era, is single in that it is derived from a single divine source, and reflects within itself the richness and historicity of the Divine Revelation, the authority of the eternal Father, the incarnate Son, and the

life-giving Spirit. It is distributed among Scripture, Tradition, Creeds, the Ministry of the Word and Sacraments, the witness of saints, and the consensus fidelium, which is the continuing experience of the Holy Spirit through his faithful people in the Church.

It is thus a dispersed rather than a centralised authority having many elements which combine, interact with, and check each other; these elements together contributing by a process of mutual support, mutual checking, and redressing of errors or exaggerations to the many-sided fullness of the authority which Christ has committed to his Church. Where this authority of Christ is to be found mediated not in one mode but in several we recognise in this multiplicity God's loving provision against the temptations to tyranny and the dangers of unchecked power.<sup>11</sup>

#### **The classical Anglican theologians**

Anglicanism does not acknowledge any human teachers as uniquely authoritative (unlike St Thomas Aquinas in Roman Catholicism, John Calvin in the Reformed Churches or John Wesley in Methodism). However, the Anglican divines of the late sixteenth to the early eighteenth centuries – from Richard Hooker to Daniel Waterland – are generally recognized as possessing unrivalled wisdom and insight (though they remain men of their time and they do not, of course, completely agree with each other). Recently this tradition has suffered from disgraceful neglect in theological education and ordination training (especially in England), but that cannot alter the fact that the thought of these scholars was formative of Anglicanism and that they belong to the common inheritance of the Anglican Communion. While they obviously need to be supplemented by more modern interpreters of Anglicanism, including those not from England, they hold an unsubstitutable place in the Anglican inheritance of faith.

Richard Hooker (1554–1600) is in a class of his own here as the prime architect of Anglican ecclesiology and the most effective defender of the so-called

Elizabethan ‘settlement’ of religion, which established the principle of comprehension or inclusiveness that is intrinsic to Anglicanism. Both the style and content of Hooker’s work, though not easy for the modern student to follow, operate at such an elevated level that they are a literary and theological education in themselves.<sup>12</sup>

#### **Questions for reflection and discussion**

What is the status of the Thirty-Nine Articles of Religion in your Church?

What continuing impact does the historic Book of Common Prayer have in your Church?

#### **For further reading**

O’Donovan, Oliver, *On the Thirty-Nine Articles: Conversations with Tudor Christianity*, 2nd edn, London: SCM Press, 2011.

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## The shape of Anglican ecclesiology

### **The Church**

Anglicans understand the Church to be primarily the one, holy, catholic and apostolic Church, the Church of Christ. Anglicans believe that they belong to the one Church of Christ. But they recognize that other, non-Anglican Christians, as individuals, also belong to the Church through baptism. They recognize that other Christian bodies corporately also belong to that Church. They affirm that each Anglican Church within the Anglican Communion is itself truly the Church, but they do not claim to comprise the Church without remainder. Anglicans have tended to use, therefore, the terms ‘part’, ‘portion’ or ‘branch’ to describe both their own Church and other Churches.

The Episcopal Church in the USA defines itself accordingly as ‘a constituent member of the Anglican Communion, a Fellowship within the One Holy Catholic and Apostolic Church, of those duly constituted Dioceses, Provinces, and Regional Churches in communion with the See of Canterbury, upholding and propagating the historic Faith and Order as set forth in the Book of Common Prayer’.

Anglicans maintain that the doctrine, worship, ministry, sacraments and government of their Churches are those of the Church of Christ and that they are owned and blessed by the Holy Spirit. Anglican Churches resolutely affirm their apostolicity and their standing as true Churches of Christ. Their ‘trust deeds’ (the historic formularies and the canons) typically do not allow their members (in practice, their clergy) to deny this. Anglicans are deeply offended when the catholic and apostolic credentials of their Church are impugned (most strongly in the Roman Catholic Church’s condemnation of Anglican orders in 1896). They hold as strongly as Roman Catholics that the designation ‘catholic’ fully belongs

to their Church, and in the creed they affirm that the Church is one, holy, catholic and apostolic.

Anglicans in England have consistently held that the Church of England is the ancient catholic Church in that land, and they profoundly resented the imposition or restoration of the Roman Catholic episcopal hierarchy when it was re-imposed in 1850. They condemned it as a piece of territorial aggression and it aroused feelings of anger in England, not unlike those generated by the Argentinian invasion of the Falkland Islands in 1982. That is not, of course, how the ecumenical movement regards the plurality of Churches, and it is clearly unhelpful to contest the right of any of the numerous branches of the Christian Church to pursue their mission anywhere. But that greater ecumenical realism does not imply any dilution of the claim to catholicity of the Anglican Churches. It simply entails that they do not for one moment deny that other Churches may also be catholic and apostolic.

At the same time that they resolutely uphold the ecclesial standing of their Church, Anglicans readily acknowledge that, like all branches of the Christian Church, without exception, Anglicanism is imperfect, provisional and incomplete in the light of the Church that is spoken of in the creeds as one, holy, catholic and apostolic. Anglicans believe that these credal attributes of the Church will only be fully revealed eschatologically, when God's saving purpose is revealed in the end time. This entails the important admission that the fragmentation of the Church into various parts or branches is not the definitive state of the Church or what God wills for it. Here Anglicans are, in effect, saying: 'We are the Church. You also are the Church. But none of us is the Church as it should be.' This acknowledgement of the incompleteness of one's own Church and recognition of the ecclesial reality of other Churches generates the commitment to the quest for Christian unity. How can the Church be divided when the body of Christ is one? Anglicans have been in the forefront of leadership of the ecumenical movement. Here again we glimpse something of the distinctive ethos of Anglican ecclesiology.

Anglicans believe that the Church on earth is united with the Church in heaven in the communion of the saints (*sanctorum communio*). They speak of 'the Church Militant here in earth' and the Church triumphant in heaven. They worship God together with 'Angels and Archangels, and with all the company of heaven'. The service 'At the Burial of the Dead' in the Book of Common Prayer (1662) includes the prayer:

Almighty God, with whom do live the spirits of them that depart hence in the Lord, and with whom the souls of the faithful, after they are delivered from the burden of the flesh, are in joy and felicity: We ... beseech[ing] thee, that it may please thee, of thy gracious goodness, shortly to accomplish the number of thine elect, and to hasten thy kingdom; that we, with all those that are departed in the true faith of thy holy name, may have our perfect consummation and bliss, both in body and soul, in thy eternal and everlasting glory.

Anglicans acknowledge that the Church of Christ on earth is manifested at various 'levels', from the universal to the very local.

First, there is the Church catholic, the universal Church. Though outwardly divided, the catholic Church consists of all Christians united to Christ in the Holy Spirit through faith and baptism and ordered in their various communities under the ministry of word, sacrament and pastoral oversight. Anglicans unequivocally recognize their fellowship with all the baptized, whatever their Christian tradition or denominational allegiance may be. The Book of Common Prayer (1662) speaks of Christians as 'very members incorporate in the mystical body of thy Son, which is the blessed company of all faithful people'.

Second, there are particular Churches, such as the member Churches of the Anglican Communion (sometimes called 'provinces'), of which the Church of England is one. A particular Church deserves the name 'national Church' when it is committed to offering its ministry to the whole national community and seeks to project its message at every level of national life. The significance that Anglicans give to national Churches (or 'provinces', as they are sometimes – rather misleadingly – called) derives from ancient usage, where dioceses were gathered into a wider unity under a primate or metropolitan (usually an archbishop). The importance of national Churches derives not only from the growing importance of national aspirations at the time of the Reformation, but also from the incarnational emphasis of Anglican theology. The Incarnation represents and establishes the involvement of God with humanity in all its particularity. Anglicanism is therefore predisposed, for theological as well as historical reasons, to work with the grain of the given contours of human and social identity, expressed through geography, political structures, cultural

traditions and the shared history of a people. The role of particular or national Churches has evolved within Anglicanism into an affirmation of the principle of inculturation – faith and worship are necessarily expressed through diverse cultural forms.

Third, there is the church of the diocese, which is often a geographical area with a common history and sense of identity. The diocese is not merely a convenient administrative unit, but is itself an expression of the Church of Christ. The diocesan bishop exercises pastoral oversight within the diocese, though he or she may share episkope (the New Testament Greek word for pastoral oversight) with suffragan or assistant or coadjutor bishops and also consults with the clergy and representative lay people, through the diocesan synod and the bishop's council, in the task of leading and governing the diocese. The bishop is also the president of the diocese as a eucharistic community and the chief minister of the sacraments. However, he or she shares the cure (care) of souls and eucharistic presidency with the clergy of the diocese. It is of the essence of a diocese that the clergy and people are in sacramental communion with their bishop. Where that communion is impaired, as it is in some Anglican dioceses over the issue of the ordination of women or issues of human sexuality, a serious anomaly has entered Anglican ecclesiology. In Anglicanism, as in Roman Catholicism and Eastern Orthodoxy, the diocese, as the sacramental community united in its bishop and as the bishop's sphere of ministry, is regarded as 'the local church', and this term has a technical meaning that is significant in Anglican ecclesiology.

Fourth, there is the parish, the most local level of the Church and the smallest unit of the Church to be formally recognized by Anglicans. In the established, territorial Church of England it is the geographical parish, rather than the worshipping congregation itself, that is recognized, and there is no membership requirement to take part in the life of the church (except as far as church government is concerned, where membership of the Church Electoral Roll is required). In most other Churches of the Anglican Communion, where territorial units of the Church are more of a modern administrative convenience than an ancient one, and where congregations may tend to be even more eclectic than they are in the Church of England, Anglicans still speak of the parish as the basic unit of the Church. Christian communities at parish level are the building blocks of the catholic Church. When they are thinking ecclesologically, Anglicans do not think of the gathered congregation as the fundamental unit of the Church, but of the diocese as the local church, comprising all the parishes within which the clergy exercise a ministry of word, sacrament and pastoral care that is

commissioned and overseen by the bishop. The parish is just as much the Church as are the universal, provincial/national and diocesan manifestations of the Church, but the two most fundamental 'levels' of the Church are the universal and the 'local' (diocesan).

The existence of a church, at any of these levels, can be identified, according to the Thirty-Nine Articles, wherever the word of God is preached and the sacraments of baptism and holy communion (Eucharist) are administered according to Christ's institution, for these indicate that Christ is present with his people in the power of the Holy Spirit (cf. Article 19 of the Thirty-Nine Articles).

## **Catholicity**

In the creed, Anglicans affirm the catholicity of the Church. It is significant that they do this precisely as Anglicans, as members of, for example, the Church of England, the Church in Wales, the Anglican Church of Australia or Canada or The Episcopal Church in the USA. For in making this affirmation, Anglicans are implying that catholicism is not synonymous with Roman Catholicism.

Anglicans maintain that there is a genuine non-Roman catholicism. Catholicity refers to the universal scope of the Church as a society instituted by God in which all sorts and conditions of humanity, all races, nations and cultures, can find a welcome and a home. The catholicity of the Church denotes its potential to fulfil the aspirations of all people. Catholicity therefore points towards inclusiveness and inculturation. It suggests that the Church has the capacity to embrace diverse ways of believing and worshipping and that this diversity comes about through the 'incarnation' of Christian truth in many different cultural forms, which it both critiques and affirms. Thus the catholicity of the Church, which in the past has often been a byword for authoritarianism, uniformity and the crushing of local traditions by central authority, is actually, when rightly understood, a mandate for cultural hospitality. Because the Church is essentially catholic, it cannot allow any group within its borders to feel patronized or marginalized, whether they are ethnic groups in a mainly white environment, working-class Christians in a mainly middle-class Church, women influenced by the feminist critique of patriarchy in a Church still largely led by

men, or those of a minority sexual orientation.

We now need to ask what the connection is between the catholicity of the Church and the Anglican insistence on the threefold order in historic succession. What has the historic episcopate to do with catholicity? While catholicity should not be defined solely by reference to holy order, nor reduced to it, Anglicans have maintained that ordination in the historical episcopal succession enhances the catholicity of the Church and helps to constitute it. In his seminal work *The Gospel and the Catholic Church*, Michael Ramsey claimed that the historic episcopate was essential to the very existence of the Church. Because the Church is a body, a visible society, Ramsey argued, it needs the historic episcopate to enable it to realize its true nature. The episcopate is the effective symbol of the corporate nature of the Church. Although Ramsey was remarkably affirming of traditions that lacked the historic episcopate – his work set a new standard for Anglicanism in this regard – he did inevitably imply that no ecclesial body that lacked it could be fully recognized as a Christian Church. However, the ecumenical theology of communion (*koinonia*) makes it possible for Anglicans to endorse the principle that Ramsey was arguing for – the intrinsic connection between the historic episcopate and the catholicity of the Church – without appearing to unchurch other, non-episcopal communions. Let us see how this can be done.

### ***Koinonia***

As recent ecumenical agreements – concluded between Anglicans and Protestants in the USA and Europe – demonstrate, Anglicans acknowledge a genuine *koinonia*, or fellowship with God the Holy Trinity and with one's fellow Christians, in Churches that do not have bishops in historical succession. Anglicans know that they would be deceiving themselves if they did not acknowledge the reality of *koinonia* in other Churches. Those communities patently enjoy 'the grace of our Lord Jesus Christ, the love of God and the fellowship of the Holy Spirit'. Manifestly they share the faith of the Church; they have baptism and the Eucharist; ministers who are commissioned by the Church and given authority to minister word and sacrament; structures of conciliarity that enable the Churches to govern themselves under the guidance of

the Holy Spirit; and forms of episkope or pastoral oversight that involve the essential biblical principle of orderly transmitted authority from person to person.

It is the reality of koinonia, grounded in the foundational sacrament of baptism, that compels Anglicans to acknowledge the authenticity of the ministries and Eucharists of Churches that are not episcopally ordered. The steps of the theological argument can be represented as follows:

Baptism unites the believer with Christ. It is, therefore, the foundation of the Christian life and the Christian ministry. The mutual recognition of baptism by the mainstream Churches, the significance accorded to baptism in the Lambeth Conferences and in the Second Vatican Council, allows us to affirm baptism as the foundational sacrament of the Church, the basis and ground of all expressions of ministry. All other ‘sacramental’ acts – confirmation, confession/penance, the Eucharist, ministerial order – are appropriations, applications or extensions of the ecclesial reality brought into being by baptism.

The rationale for this primary affirmation of the significance of baptism is found in the doctrine that baptism incorporates believers into the body of Christ, the Church (1 Corinthians 12.12–13), whereby they participate in Christ’s threefold messianic office as prophet, priest and king. All members of this royal priesthood exercise it in a continual offering of spiritual sacrifices to God through Christ. That sacrifice is first and foremost of themselves (Romans 12.1), and its chief expression is through the Eucharist, when we are united with Christ’s self-oblation to the Father, caught up in the movement of his self-offering.

The Church needs to set apart some members of the whole people of God (New Testament Greek: *laos*), to represent and minister to its own inherent priesthood and to reflect it back, so bringing to light the priestly nature of the whole body and of every member in particular. When the Church does this, it imparts authority for some to act in a representative way on behalf of all. It is not as though baptized Christians do not already fully participate in Christ’s royal priesthood. But what ordination does is to set some apart for the representative ministry as an ‘economy’ (a useful patristic and Orthodox term implying some

temporary restriction or narrowing down for the sake of the long-term well-being of the whole) within the body. The commissioning or ordination that they receive is real, awesome and effective. When fellow ministers or bishops bestow such authority, they do so not so much in the name of their order as in the name of Christ and the whole body of the Church. The ordained ministry thus becomes an ecclesial sign – showing something that is true of the nature of the Church as a whole.<sup>1</sup>

The only proper theological criterion for assessing the authenticity of a Church's ordained ministry – and with it the authenticity of its sacraments, especially the Eucharist – is whether it is manifestly the reflection and expression of the koinonia of that body, the life of communion with Christ and one another, that flows from the baptismal incorporation of all believers into Christ. Mutual recognition of baptism combines with the growing awareness of common ground in the experience of koinonia to create a powerful momentum towards mutual recognition as Churches of Christ with authentic ministries and sacraments. As far as Anglicans are concerned, that alone will not be sufficient for full, visible, structural unity, which represents a further stage in which the episcopate as a focus of unity and of visible continuity with the Church of the apostles must come into play, but it is the essential prerequisite for the supreme challenge of finding a basis for that ultimate step.

Anglicans have not insisted on the historic episcopate as a precondition for recognition of another Church as a true Church, or for offering eucharistic hospitality or even for shared celebrations (in some sense) of the Eucharist, but they do continue to regard the historic episcopate as an essential aspect of the Church's catholicity and therefore as a prerequisite for visible unity, including the reconciliation of ordained ministries). As Henry Chadwick has put it:

The point should not be represented as if episcopacy is the article of faith by which the church stands or falls, or as if it is the only possible instrument of unity; still less an infallible guarantee against the incidence of schism. The claim is not being made that the episcopate is of the being of the church in the sense that it is constitutive in the same way and on the same plane as the sacraments of baptism or eucharist or the true proclamation of God's Word. But unity and universality are of the church's very being ... And the episcopal ministry in due succession and apostolic commission is the immemorial tradition of the catholic

church ... and therefore is also a providential instrument of the true marks of the church as a visible society in history.<sup>2</sup>

Episcopal ordination in historic succession and in communion with the college of bishops of the universal Church (as far as that is possible in a divided Church) is a canonical requirement of Anglicanism and part of its distinctive discipline and polity. Moreover, Anglicans share it with the largest and most historic Christian communions: the Roman Catholic, Orthodox, Nordic and Baltic Lutheran, and Old Catholic Churches. Anglicans value it as an aspect of the catholicity and apostolicity of Anglicanism. In terms of the current ecumenical consensus, it is a sign but not a guarantee of the apostolicity and catholicity of the Church. In practice, episcopal ordination is a non-negotiable platform of Anglicanism in ecumenical discussions, whatever temporary anomalies may be entertained in order to reach the goal of visible unity.

### **Apostolicity**

In the Nicene-Constantinopolitan creed (the one normally used at the Eucharist), Anglicans, like many other Christians, affirm also the apostolicity of the Church. The very first of the Church of England's canons asserts that it belongs to 'the true and apostolic' Church of Christ and that no member shall be free to deny that (Canon A1). The apostolicity of the Church has been a recurring theme of recent ecumenical dialogue involving Anglicans. The Churches have come to see that apostolicity is an attribute of the whole Church and stands for the momentum of the Church in mission. The Church derives its apostolicity ultimately from the mission that the Son receives from the Father and conveys to the Church, together with the gift of the Holy Spirit. "As the Father has sent me, so I send you." When he had said this, he breathed on them and said to them, "Receive the Holy Spirit ..." (John 20.21–22). The Lima Statement of the Faith and Order Commission of the World Council of Churches, Baptism, Eucharist and Ministry (1982), defined the apostolicity of the Church in terms of its multifaceted continuity with the life of the early Christians. 'Apostolic tradition in the Church means continuity in the permanent characteristics of the Church of

the apostles.’<sup>3</sup> Apostolicity is predicated primarily of the whole body, the life in grace of the people of God. So when we speak, as we may, of an apostolic ministry, we should be clear that this is set within an equally apostolic community.

It follows from this premise of the inalienable apostolicity of the Church of Christ that any Church that is caught up in the mission of God in Christ through the Holy Spirit and can show visible continuity with the Church of the apostles can be recognized as sharing in the apostolic mission. Its ministries and sacraments are manifestations of its essential apostolicity. If it has bishops in historic succession, they serve as a sign and instrument, though not as a guarantee, of apostolicity. Historic episcopal succession, together with the ordination of presbyters and deacons by bishops within the succession, is a sign of God’s faithfulness to the Church through history. It is also a sign of the Church’s intention to remain faithful to the teaching and mission of the apostles. It assures the faithful of that intention. It is, so to speak, a sacramental link with the Church of the apostles who were called, taught and commissioned by Jesus Christ himself and were chosen witnesses of his resurrection. It demonstrates that the Church does not feel free to cut loose from the authority of the apostolic Church but, on the contrary, believes that it is called above all to faithfulness to the gospel and to the community of the gospel with its sacraments and ministries.

However, the Porvoo agreement between the British and Irish Anglican Churches and the Nordic and Baltic Lutheran Churches has made it possible for Anglicans to take a less literalistic view of what historic succession means. These Anglican Churches have extended recognition to the episcopal succession of the Norwegian and Danish Churches, even though the succession of episcopal consecrations and ordinations was temporarily broken in the Reformation period. They have done this on three grounds, which they judge make up for that anomaly (on the principle that the Church, acting in good faith and with the right intention, has the fullness of grace to compensate for any human deficiencies, the principle of *Ecclesia supplet*). Those grounds are: first, the intention was to ordain bishops, even though they were consecrated by a presbyter (Martin Luther’s colleague Johann Bugenhagen); second, the succession of bishops in those Churches since then has been maintained; third, there has been continuity of episkope (pastoral oversight) in the historic sees (a principle that was important to the early Church). In this significant development of Anglican thinking about the historic succession, we see a concentration on the spirit rather

than the letter: it is the intention of the Church that counts, rather than the mechanics of succession.<sup>4</sup>

## **Catholicity and apostolicity**

What then is the relationship between catholicity and apostolicity? The attributes of catholicity should be distinguished from those of apostolicity. Can we elicit the nature of the connection or distinction between them?

Apostolicity is the dimension of depth in the Church, its extension in time, its forward momentum in mission. Apostolicity has to do with the authenticity of the Church; its faithfulness to its apostolic foundation; the reality of the apostolic mission in the mission of the Church today.

Catholicity is the dimension of breadth in the Church, its extension in space, its aspiration to universality. Catholicity has to do with fullness and completeness; the inclusivity of the Church; the presence of the whole Church in the local churches.

Anglicans understand episcopacy in the light of both the catholicity and the apostolicity of the Church. As the Lambeth Quadrilateral suggests, Anglicans do not set the historic episcopate above the Bible, the creeds and the sacraments; it quite clearly takes fourth place after these. But it is significant that the Quadrilateral draws on both Scripture and tradition. If we receive the gospel and the dominical sacraments on the authority of Scripture, we receive the canon of Scripture, the ecumenical creeds and the historic episcopate from tradition. Anglicans (and for that matter, other catholic Christians who recognize the role of tradition) should not be criticized because they base the claims of the historic episcopate on tradition: the canon and the creeds are also grounded purely on

tradition. Non-episcopal Churches that retain the canon and the creeds may be helped, by reflecting on the significance of that fact, to recognize that tradition also makes a claim upon us with regard to episcopacy.

### **Unity in baptism and Eucharist**

Anglicans believe that unity is an essential attribute of the Church of Christ and that it is grounded in the Trinitarian unity of the God. For Anglicans, as Hooker taught, the indestructible unity of Christians in Christ through baptism is of the revealed essence of Christianity, for there is ‘one Lord, one faith, one baptism, one God and Father of all’ (Ephesians 4.4). Although this unity will be fully manifested only in the last time, at the coming of the kingdom (that is, eschatologically), the imperative of seeking to realize this God-given unity in practical, tangible, structured ways is laid upon us now by the New Testament. The unity of the Church is therefore both a divine gift and a Christian calling.

Through their commitment to the ecumenical movement, Anglicans have consistently testified that the unity of the Church, as an imperative of Christian obedience, is a condition of the Church’s mission: ‘that they may all be one ... that the world may believe’ (John 17.20–21). It is also part of God’s plan for the unity of all things in heaven and earth in Christ, so that God may be all in all (Colossians 1.20). By endorsing recent ecumenical insights (particularly those of Baptism, Eucharist and Ministry), Anglicans have indicated that they believe the Church to be a sign, instrument and foretaste of this eschatological unity. To the extent that the Church itself is divided, its effectiveness as a sign of the kingdom is impaired.

Anglicans hold that the unity of the Church is grounded in the one baptism. They have been among the first to perceive the ecumenical significance of the mutual recognition of baptism by the Churches. The famous Appeal for Christian unity by the Lambeth Conference of 1920 was addressed to all those throughout the world who had received Christian baptism. Baptism unites us to Christ in his death and resurrection. It incorporates us into his divinely anointed body, the Church, and we participate in his threefold messianic office as prophet, priest and king. Baptism therefore makes all Christians into a holy, royal, priesthood.

Baptism is a dynamic reality that contains an inherent drive towards deeper unity, primarily in the one Eucharist, as we seek to realize together the true nature of the body of Christ.

By their practice of eucharistic hospitality, Anglicans show that they believe that the common baptism calls for unity in the Eucharist, for that is where the body of Christ, to which we already belong by baptism, is most fully known. The Eucharist, or Holy Communion, is the paradigm of *koinonia*, and this concept – so fruitful in current ecumenical work – is particularly congenial to Anglicans. They have contributed to the ecumenical theology of communion, and this theology is reflected particularly in the documents of the 1988 Lambeth Conference.<sup>5</sup> We are already fundamentally in communion with each other through baptism, but that communion only comes to its full realization – this side of heaven – in the unity of the Eucharist, the ‘holy communion’. At that moment, our communion with Christ and our communion with each other are inseparable and, perhaps, indistinguishable.

Where does eucharistic communion fit into the process of becoming more visibly united? Anglicans do not regard the achievement of a common Eucharist, in its ecumenical context, as the final reward for a unity already attained in the spheres of faith and of order, as the Roman Catholic and Orthodox Churches do. But neither do they see it as merely a pragmatic device for artificially promoting a unity that does not yet really exist. Rather, Anglicans see the Eucharist as the sacrament of unity in the sense that the communion that is already a reality through our common baptism and our common baptismal faith comes to fruition and expression there and may become more and more complete as progress in visible unity is achieved.

## **Diversity**

As members of a culturally diverse worldwide communion of Churches, Anglicans are habituated to the idea that communion can co-exist with considerable diversity of belief and practice. The varieties of faith and practice that are a feature of Anglicanism are held together at a fundamental level in the communion that Anglicans have with one another in the common Eucharist.

That does not mean that all varieties of belief and practice are equally valid, or that the differences do not matter, or that Anglicans should not be striving for greater coherence and cohesion; only that there is something that is greater, deeper and stronger than all these differences: the fact that all the baptized belong to the one Christ and in him to one another. It is this transcendent condition of ecclesial existence that is operative in the Eucharist.

The nature of the Anglican Communion, as a fellowship of churches that practise comprehension and toleration on the basis of a common core of fundamental tenets of faith and order, suggests that the model of unity that is most congenial to Anglicans is that of ‘communion in diversity’. This is a good deal stronger than the familiar ecumenical expression ‘reconciled diversity’. Real communion involves much more than the mutual acceptance of differences. It implies an agreed fundamental faith, a common life of sacramental worship, interchangeability of ministers, the practice of conciliarity with joint policy-making, mutual accountability, and unity in episkope (however that might be worked out in practice).

Unity is focused and sustained in Anglican Churches tacitly as well as explicitly. Alongside the explicit structures of common credal faith and sacramental practice, of government and oversight, there stands a common tradition that embraces liturgy, theology, spirituality and pastoral care. It is this common tradition – a distinctive Anglican ecclesial culture – that underpins the more structural and formal safeguards of unity such as synods, bishops, metropolitans and canon law.

It belongs to the ethos of Anglicanism – which owes more than is usually recognized to the pre-Reformation Conciliar Movement in the Western Church – that its structures of unity should be operated constitutionally and in a representative way and in a way that respects the need for the consent of the faithful.<sup>6</sup> Leadership in Anglicanism is located in the-bishop-in-synod. Anglicans are averse, by tradition and conviction, to hierarchical, monarchical and authoritarian methods of leadership and to attempts to impose a monolithic uniformity. Anglicanism does not find a juridical approach to the unity of the Church at all congenial, and its church courts are used only in extreme cases of ecclesiastical discipline.

## **The visibility of the Church and its unity**

Anglicans are committed, by their tradition of ecclesiology, to working for the visible expression of the Church's unity. They do not believe that a spiritual, inward unity is enough. Article 19 of the Thirty-Nine Articles focuses entirely on the visible Church. It defines it as 'a congregation of faithful men, in the which the pure Word of God is preached, and the Sacraments be duly ministered according to Christ's ordinance'. There are two points that I would like to draw out from this Article.

First, the word 'congregation' in Article 19 almost certainly does not mean the local worshipping congregation. The Latin text of the Article has the phrase *coetus fidelium* (assembly of the faithful). This Article is based on Article 7 of the Augsburg Confession of Luther's Reformation, in which the equivalent expression is *congregatio Sanctorum* (assembly of the saints). *Coetus* is virtually a synonym for *congregatio* (assembly, society), which corresponds to the Greek *ekklesia*, which we have already seen means an assembly of people. The Article is not primarily referring to what we understand by a worshipping congregation in a parish (though this is certainly not excluded, since it too must have an ecclesial integrity grounded in word and sacrament), but to a 'particular' Church, which for the English Reformers meant a national Church made up of dioceses. That is the flock within which word and sacrament are administered and pastoral oversight is exercised. The 'local church' in Anglican ecclesiology denotes (as we have already seen) the community of word and sacrament gathered, governed and led by the bishop. For Anglican ecclesiology, the 'congregation' in the strict sense is the diocese.

Second, contrary to a popular misconception, the Churches of the Reformation (the Church of England among them) did not think of the Christian Church as essentially invisible. True, they stressed the mystery of the Church as 'hidden with Christ in God' (Colossians 3.3), and there is undoubtedly an invisible dimension to Christ's Church. But the Reformers believed that the true Church would never cease to exist in a visible form on earth. Thus they held the catholic doctrine of the 'indefectibility' of the Church. Richard Hooker spoke of the visible and 'mystical' (not invisible) aspects of the Church. It belongs to the catholicity of Anglicanism that it acknowledges the Church to be a visible, universal society, with visible, tangible structures of its common life. The unity

with other Churches that Anglicans seek is therefore certainly a visible unity. It would have to be embodied in structural, institutional forms. This concern is grounded for Anglicans in the normative model of the Incarnation, which is the real visible embodiment of God in human life. The visibility of the Church, and therefore of its unity, is expressed in a number of ways: the public reading of the Scriptures, the preaching of the gospel, the administration of the sacraments, pastoral care, the exercise of episkope and the practice of conciliarity in church government. These all entail visible, structural and institutional forms. They make us visible to each other and visible to the world. Anglicans seek a unity that incorporates and works through all these various outward forms.

### **A blueprint for the Church?**

In its historic formularies, Anglicanism does not claim that any particular visible structures of the Church are of binding divine institution (*jure divino*). In that strict sense, Anglicans would find it difficult to maintain that there is a divine constitution for the outward ordering of the Church. Anglicans have generally assumed that ecclesiastical polity should be shaped by reason and tradition, while it should certainly not be contrary to Scripture. For example, to assert, as Hooker does, that episcopacy is of apostolic origin is not quite the same as claiming that it is a divinely instituted and irreplaceable form of church government. Anglicans have recognized that there is a distinction to be drawn between episkope as such (the New Testament's term for pastoral oversight) and the historic episcopate as one expression or implementation of this – or to put it another way, between the principle of transmitted authority and the contingent historical structures through which Christ's commission is mediated to the Church and its ministers in every generation. For example, the Lambeth Conference of 1920 proposed the historic episcopate as an appropriate basis for unity precisely because it was the most widely accepted form of episkope. Anglicans are committed to the historic episcopate; they are wedded to it and do not feel at liberty to compromise on it.

Though Anglicanism does not claim that there is a divine constitution for the Church to be lifted from the pages of the New Testament, it does hold that certain principles of abiding validity may be discerned there. As the Ordinal

shows, Anglicans believe that Christ commissioned certain of his disciples to preach the gospel, heal the afflicted, spread his teachings, forgive sins, administer the sacraments (certainly at least baptism at this stage) and care for his sheep (Matthew 28.18–20; John 20.21–23). In this commission, Anglicans believe that a ministry of word and sacrament, of absolution and of effective episkope, is entailed. The form of this episkope should be of the widest acceptability and provide scope for local adaptation. For Anglicans this criterion points to the threefold order of bishops, priests and deacons, and to historic continuity of ordinations by bishops.

Anglicans, in gladly acknowledging the apostolicity of other Churches, invite them to a mutual sharing of apostolic gifts. It is unlikely that any Anglican Church could be a serious partner in a scheme of visible unity that did not involve all participating Churches eventually sharing in the historic episcopate. Anglicans would not be requiring this in order to make the ministries of non-episcopal Churches true ministries of the word and sacraments in the Church of Christ for the first time, as though they were not that already (they recognize that as a reality by virtue of the apostolicity of the whole Church in its enjoyment of the Trinitarian koinonia and in its apostolic mission), but it would be required in order to give effect to the visible unity of the Church through the effective sign of apostolicity, the historic episcopate.

### **Universality**

For Anglicans, the visible communion of the Church should come to expression at each of the various levels of the Church:

in the parish, through one eucharistic fellowship in each place with an episcopally ordained priestly president;

in the diocese ('local church'), through the one bishop acting in council with his or her assistant bishops, together with the priests, deacons and lay persons, in

one synod;

provincially or nationally, through a united college of bishops and a synod in which bishops, clergy and laity are represented;

internationally or globally, through appropriate structures of consultation, discernment and decision-making (conciliarity), with a president accepted by all.

That final point raises the question of the office of a universal primacy. The principle of a primacy wider than the province or national Church is not alien to Anglicanism. The Archbishop of Canterbury has a primacy in the Anglican Communion, though he remains first among equals (*primus inter pares*). Anglicans have not excluded the possibility in principle of a universal primate. The statements on authority of the ARCIC Final Report, which not surprisingly suggested that the Bishop of Rome would be a suitable candidate for universal primate in a united Church, was acknowledged as a useful contribution to ongoing discussion by the 1988 Lambeth Conference, and the bishops of the Church of England gave a cordial but not uncritical response to the Pope's encyclical, *Ut Unum Sint*, of 1995. The idea of an Anglican 'reception' (evaluation, critical assimilation) of papal primacy has once again been raised in a fairly sharp form by the ARCIC report, *The Gift of Authority* (1999).

In any consideration of universal primacy, Anglicans would want to stand firm on their foundational principles – which go back to the Conciliar Movement of the fourteenth and fifteenth centuries – of dispersed authority, constitutional constraints on authority, the principle of consent, and representative synods that include elected lay people and clergy other than bishops. To speculate whether, on those terms, it is realistic to hope that agreement on primacy could be reached with the Roman Catholic Church, where the pope has universal immediate jurisdiction, power of infallible utterance and a veto in councils of bishops and requires implicit obedience to his routine teaching in faith and morals, would go beyond the scope of this brief introduction to the Anglican understanding of the Church of Christ.

**Questions for reflection and discussion**

What do we mean by (a) the catholicity and (b) the apostolicity of the Church?

Does it make sense to see the diocese as ‘the local church’?

What prevents Anglican Churches from recognizing the authority of the pope?

**For further reading**

Hanson, A. T. and Hanson, R. P. C., *The Identity of the Church: A Guide to Recognizing the Contemporary Church*, London: SCM Press, 1987.

Hardy, Daniel W., *Finding the Church: The Dynamic Truth of Anglicanism*, London: SCM Press, 2001.

Podmore, Colin, *Aspects of Anglican Identity*, London: Church House Publishing, 2005.

## Notes

### **1 The spirit of Anglican ecclesiology**

1 A. M. Ramsey, *The Gospel and the Catholic Church* (London: Longmans, 1936), p. 220.

2 I tend to use the word ‘church’ rather than ‘denomination’; for the reasons for this usage, see Paul Avis, ‘Denomination: An Anglican Appraisal’, in Paul M. Collins and Barry Ensign-George (eds), *Denomination: Assessing an Ecclesiological Category* (London and New York: T&T Clark, 2011), pp. 22–33.

3 For an evaluation of ‘fresh expressions’, see *Fresh Expressions in the Mission of the Church: Report of an Anglican–Methodist Working Party* (London: Church House Publishing, 2012). For signs of hope in local ministry and mission, see David Goodhew (ed.), *Church Growth in Britain: 1980 to the Present* (Farnham, Surrey and Burlington, VT: Ashgate, 2012).

### **3 The quest for Anglican ecclesiology**

1 Stephen Sykes, *Unashamed Anglicanism* (London: Darton, Longman & Todd, 1995), p. 32.

2 Philip Thomas in Stephen Sykes, John Booty and Jonathan Knight (eds), *The Study of Anglicanism* (London: SPCK, 1998), p. 250.

3 John Bunyan, *The Pilgrim's Progress from this world to that which is to come, delivered under the similitude of a dream*, *The World's Classics* (London: Oxford University Press, 1902 [1678, 1684]).

4 Anglican–Roman Catholic International Commission, *Salvation and the Church: An Agreed Statement by the Second Anglican–Roman Catholic International Commission ARCIC II* (London: Church House Publishing/Catholic Truth Society, 1987).

5 Mark Chapman, *Anglican Theology* (London and New York: T&T Clark, 2012).

6 Stephen Sykes, *The Integrity of Anglicanism* (London and Oxford: Mowbray, 1978).

7 Roger Coleman, *Resolutions of the Twelve Lambeth Conferences 1867–1988* (Toronto: Anglican Book Centre, 1992), pp. 83ff.

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9 On the Covenant, see Mark D. Chapman (ed.), *The Anglican Covenant: Unity and Diversity in the Anglican Communion* (London and New York: Mowbray, 2008); Benjamin M. Guyer (ed.), *Pro Communion: Theological Essays on the Anglican Covenant* (Eugene, OR: Pickwick Publications, 2012).

## **4 Three models of Anglican self-understanding**

1 Paul Avis, *Anglicanism and the Christian Church: Theological Resources in Historical Perspective* (London and New York: T&T Clark, 2002).

2 Charles Carlton, *Archbishop William Laud* (London: Routledge, 1987), pp. 53, 63.

3 John Neville Figgis, *The Divine Right of Kings*, 2nd edn (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1922), pp. 142–3.

4 For the Australian example, see Bruce Kaye, *A Church without Walls: Being Anglican in Australia* (Victoria: Dove, 1995).

5 Avis, *Anglicanism and the Christian Church*.

6 Sheridan Gilley, *Newman and his Age* (London: Darton, Longman & Todd, 1990); Frank M. Turner, *John Henry Newman: The Challenge to Evangelical Religion* (New Haven and London: Yale University Press, 2002).

7 John Henry Newman, *An Essay on the Development of Christian Doctrine: The Edition of 1845*, ed. with an introduction by J. M. Cameron (Harmondsworth: Penguin, 1974).

8 Baptism, Eucharist and Ministry (Geneva: World Council of Churches, 1982), M34.

9 On koinonia and communion ecclesiology, see Thomas Best and Günter Gassmann (eds), *On the Way to Fuller Koinonia: Official Report of the Fifth World Conference on Faith and Order* (Geneva: World Council of Churches, 1994), pp. 37–69 (John Reumann, ‘Koinonia in Scripture: Survey of Biblical Texts’); Anglican–Roman Catholic International Commission, *Church as Communion* (London: SPCK and CTS, 1990); Dennis Doyle, *Communion Ecclesiology* (Maryknoll, NY: Orbis, 2000).

10 F. D. Maurice, *The Kingdom of Christ*, 2 vols, ed. Alec Vidler (London: SCM Press, 1958), vol. 2, p. 125.

11 See Paul Avis (ed.), *The Journey of Christian Initiation: Theological and Pastoral Perspectives* (London: Church House Publishing, 2011).

12 See Paul Avis, *The Identity of Anglicanism: Essentials of Anglican Ecclesiology* (London and New York: T&T Clark, 2008), chs 6 and 7.

13 Groupe des Dombes, *For the Conversion of the Churches* (Geneva: World Council of Churches, 1993).

14 See further on this point, Paul Avis, *Reshaping Ecumenical Theology: The Church Made Whole* (London and New York: T&T Clark, 2010), ch. 8, ‘Building and Breaking Communion’.

## **5 The threefold appeal of Anglican ecclesiology**

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2 Anglican–Roman Catholic International Commission (ARCIC), *The Final Report* (London: SPCK and CTS, 1982); ARCIC, *The Gift of Authority* (London: CTS; Toronto: Anglican Book Centre; New York: Church Publishing Inc., 1999); *May They All Be One: A Response of the House of Bishops of the Church of England to Ut Unum Sint* (London: Church House Publishing, 1997).

3 George Guiver, *Faith in Momentum* (London: SPCK, 1990), p. 102.

4 Charles Gore, *Roman Catholic Claims* (London: Longmans, Green & Co., 1884).

5 See *The Church of the Triune God: The Cyprus Agreed Statement of the International Commission for Anglican–Orthodox Theological Dialogue* (London: Anglican Communion Office, 2006).

6 On this point, see Paul Avis, *Anglicanism and the Christian Church: Theological Resources in Historical Perspective* (London and New York: T&T Clark, 2002), chs 10–12.

7 Richard Hooker, *Of the Laws of Ecclesiastical Polity*, V, lxxxi, 5–17.

8 A. M. Ramsey, *The Gospel and the Catholic Church* (London: Longmans, 1936).

## **6 The sources of Anglican ecclesiology**

1 For the various editions, see Brian Cummings (ed.), *The Book of Common Prayer: The Texts of 1549, 1559, and 1662* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2011). See also Paul Avis, 'The Book of Common Prayer and Anglicanism: Worship and Belief', in Stephen Platten and Christopher Woods (eds), *Comfortable Words: Polity and Piety and the Book of Common Prayer* (London: SCM Press, 2012), pp. 132–51.

2 Louis Weil, 'The Gospel in Anglicanism', in Stephen Sykes, John Booty and Jonathan Knight (eds), *The Study of Anglicanism*, 2nd edn (London: SPCK, 1998), p. 67.

3 See further Paul Avis, *A Ministry Shaped by Mission* (London and New York: T&T Clark, 2005).

4 See *For Such a Time as This: The Distinctive Diaconate in the Church of England* (London: Church House Publishing, 2001).

5 See *Eucharistic Presidency, A Statement by the House of Bishops of the Church of England* (London: Church House Publishing, 1997).

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7 Norman Doe, *The Legal Framework of the Church of England* (Oxford: Clarendon Press, 1996); Mark Hill, *Ecclesiastical Law*, 3rd edn (Oxford: Oxford

University Press, 2007).

8 J. Robert Wright, 'Prolegomena to a Study of Anglican Ecclesiology', in D. S. Armentrout (ed.), *This Sacred History* (Cambridge, MA: Cowley Press, 1990), pp. 243–56 at pp. 253–4.

9 R. Coleman (ed.), *Resolutions of the Twelve Lambeth Conferences*, pp. 45–48 (Resolution 9).

10 See further, J. Robert Wright (ed.), *Quadrilateral at One Hundred: Essays on the Centenary of the Chicago-Lambeth Quadrilateral 1886/88–1986/88*, Supplementary Series, no. 10, *Anglican Theological Review* (March 1988); also: Cincinnati, OH: Forward Movement Publications and London and Oxford: Mowbray, 1988.

11 The Lambeth Conference 1948: The Encyclical Letter from the Bishops; together with Resolutions and Reports (London: SPCK, 1948), part II, pp. 84–6.

12 The definitive edition of Hooker's Works is the Folger Shakespeare Library edition, which may be found in the best libraries: W. Speed Hill (ed.): vols I–V (Cambridge, MA and London: Belknap Press of Harvard University Press, 1977–90); vol. VI (Binghamton, NY: Medieval and Renaissance Texts and Studies, 1993); vol. VII (Tempe, AZ: Medieval and Renaissance Texts and Studies, 1998). More accessible, though not offering a definitive text, is John Keble's edition, 3 vols, 3rd edn (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 1845). For an introduction to Hooker and many other classical Anglican divines, see Paul Avis, *Anglicanism and the Christian Church: Theological Resources in Historical Perspective* (London and New York, T&T Clark, 2002). For a comprehensive introduction to Hooker's thought, see Torrance Kirby (ed.), *A Companion to Richard Hooker*, with a Foreword by Rowan Williams (Leiden and Boston: Brill, 2008). Also important, though not for the novice, is A. J. Joyce, *Richard Hooker and Anglican Moral Theology* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2012). A classic anthology of Anglican writing of the seventeenth century is P. E. More and F. M. Cross (eds), *Anglicanism: The Thought and Practice of the Church of England, Illustrated from the Religious Literature of the Seventeenth Century* (London: SPCK, 1935).

## **7 The shape of Anglican ecclesiology**

1 See further Paul Avis, *A Ministry Shaped by Mission* (London and New York: T&T Clark, 2005).

2 Henry Chadwick, *Tradition and Exploration: Collected Papers on Theology and the Church* (Norwich: Canterbury Press, 1994), p. 88.

3 Baptism, Eucharist and Ministry (Geneva: World Council of Churches, 1982), M34, p. 28.

4 *Together in Mission and Ministry: The Porvoo Common Statement with Essays on Church and Ministry in Northern Europe* (London: Church House Publishing, 1993); John Halliburton, 'Bishops Together in Mission and Ministry: The Understanding of Episcopacy in the Porvoo Common Statement', *Theology* 101:802 (1998), pp. 253–62.

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6 Paul Avis, *Beyond the Reformation? Authority, Primacy and Unity in the Conciliar Tradition* (London and New York: T&T Clark, 2006).

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Athanasius, St

Augustine, St, Archbishop of Canterbury

Avis, Paul

Badcock, Gary D.

Bagot, Richard, Bishop

Baptists

Barth, Karl

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Benedict XVI, Pope

Beza, Theodore

Booty, John

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Bunyan, John

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Cameron, J. M.

Carlton, Charles

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Church in Wales

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Henry VIII

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